Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 12 · DAYS 379-420

Hezekiah, Isaiah and the Assyrian Crisis

2 Kings 18-20, Isaiah 1-39, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah

God's holiness, judgment, and the great hope of a servant who will bear the sins of many.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory."

ISAIAH 6:3

Psalms 46, 48, 75, 76, 80, 81, and 83 beside Assyria's threat. Psalms 22, 69, and 89 beside Isaiah's servant.

UNIT 12

In this unit

WEEK 55

379	2 Kings 18:1-20:21	*Reading*
380	Isaiah 1:1-3:26	*Reading*
381	Isaiah 4:1-5:30	*Reading*
382	Psalm 80	*Psalm*
383	Psalm 81	*Psalm*
384	Isaiah 6:1-8:22	*Reading*
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WEEK 56

386	Isaiah 6:1-7; 1 Peter 1:14-16	*Doctrine*
387	Isaiah 9:1-12:6	*Reading*
388	Isaiah 13:1-17:14	*Reading*
389	Isaiah 18:1-23:18	*Reading*
390	Psalm 75	*Psalm*
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WEEK 57

393	Psalm 83	*Psalm*
394	Isaiah 24:1-27:13	*Reading*
395	Isaiah 28:1-30:33	*Reading*
396	Isaiah 31:1-35:10	*Reading*
397	Isaiah 36:1-37:38	*Reading*
398	Isaiah 38:1-39:8	*Reading*
399	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 58

400	Psalm 46	*Psalm*

401	Psalm 48	*Psalm*
402	Isaiah 40:1-42:25	*Reading*
403	Isaiah 43:1-45:25	*Reading*
404	Psalm 86	*Psalm*
405	Psalm 89:1-37	*Psalm*
406	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 59

407	Isaiah 46:1-49:26	*Reading*
408	Isaiah 50:1-53:12	*Reading*
409	Isaiah 53:1-12; Romans 3:21-26; Hebrews 9:11-28	*Doctrine*
410	Isaiah 54:1-57:21	*Reading*
411	Psalm 22	*Psalm*
412	Psalm 69:1-21	*Psalm*
413	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 60

414	Isaiah 58:1-60:22	*Reading*
415	Isaiah 61:1-63:14	*Reading*
416	Isaiah 63:15-66:24	*Reading*
417	Nahum 1:1-3:19	*Reading*
418	Habakkuk 1:1-3:19	*Reading*
419	Zephaniah 1:1-3:20	*Reading*
420	Review and Reflection	*Review and Sabbath*

DAY 379 · WEEK 55

2 Kings 18:1-20:21

Hezekiah's faithfulness; the Assyrian threat; deliverance

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 18:1-20:21. After the fall of Samaria, Judah stands alone against Assyria. Read Hezekiah's story as a test of what faith does when the empire is at the gate, and notice the sad ending in chapter 20.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Hezekiah became king of Judah around 715 BC, a few years after Samaria fell. He is one of the best kings in Judah's history. He removed the high places, destroyed the bronze serpent Moses had made, and trusted the LORD. Assyria, the empire that had swallowed the north, now turned on Judah. This unit follows that crisis from the viewpoint of the king and of the prophet Isaiah, who spoke to him throughout.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He trusted in the LORD, the God of Israel, so that there was none like him among all the kings of Judah after him" (18:5).
2. "He broke in pieces the bronze serpent that Moses had made, for until those days the people of Israel had made offerings to it" (18:4).
3. "In the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah, Sennacherib king of Assyria came up against all the fortified cities of Judah and took them" (18:13).
4. The Rabshakeh asks, "On what do you rest this trust of yours?" (18:19).
5. "Do not let Hezekiah make you trust in the LORD by saying, The LORD will surely deliver us" (18:30).
6. Hezekiah spreads the letter before the LORD and prays (19:14-19).

7. “For I will defend this city to save it, for my own sake and for the sake of my servant David” (19:34).

8. Hezekiah shows the Babylonian envoys all his treasures, and Isaiah says, “Days are coming when all that is in your house… shall be carried to Babylon” (20:12-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hezekiah’s reforms show what real faith looks like in leadership. He did not merely keep the temple clean. He destroyed the bronze serpent, a God-given object that had turned into an idol. Even good things from the past become dangerous when people worship them. The writer says there was none like him in his trust in the LORD.

Then the crisis comes. Sennacherib captures the fortified cities and Hezekiah, at first, tries to buy him off with silver stripped from the temple. It fails. The Assyrian spokesman then delivers a speech designed to break the people’s confidence. He asks the central question: “On what do you rest this trust of yours?” He argues that Egypt is a broken reed, that Hezekiah’s reforms have offended God, and that no god of any nation has ever stopped Assyria. He speaks Hebrew loudly so that the people on the wall will hear. This is psychological warfare.

Hezekiah’s response is the model. He tears his clothes, goes to the temple, and sends to Isaiah. When a threatening letter arrives, he does something striking: he spreads it out before the LORD. He brings the threat into God’s presence and prays that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that the LORD alone is God. God answers through Isaiah and strikes down the Assyrian army in the night.

Chapter 20 turns to Hezekiah’s illness and recovery, and then to a quiet failure. When envoys from Babylon come, he shows them everything, perhaps proud of his wealth, perhaps hoping for an alliance. Isaiah tells him the day will come when it is all carried off to Babylon. Hezekiah responds with a short-sighted relief that there will be peace in his days. The great king who trusted God in the crisis is weaker in prosperity. Faith has to be kept through easy times as well.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Whoever believes in me will not be put to shame” (Romans 10:11 quotes Isaiah). Hezekiah’s prayer, spreading a trouble before the LORD, anticipates Philippians 4:6 and 1 Peter 5:7. Paul calls on us to “take every thought captive” (2 Corinthians 10:5) against arguments raised against the knowledge of God. The bronze serpent lifted by Moses became a picture of Christ lifted up (John 3:14), but it was not to be worshiped in itself.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether anything good from your past, a ministry, habit, or tradition, has become something you rely on more than God.

Take a worry or a threatening message and spread it out before the LORD in prayer.

Watch for pride in good times. Ask God for humility when things are going well.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what voices ask you to rest on something else, and say you rest on him.

Spread your fears before him, as Hezekiah spread the letter.

Thank him for the deliverance he has given.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 380 · WEEK 55

Isaiah 1:1-3:26

God's indictment; Zion's daughters, covenant lawsuit

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 1:1-3:26. Isaiah is the longest and most quoted prophet in the New Testament. Read the opening chapters as a courtroom scene, and listen for God's offer in 1:18.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah son of Amoz prophesied in Jerusalem during the reigns of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, roughly 740 to 690 BC. He was probably a man of standing in the city, with access to kings. The book that bears his name has sixty-six chapters, and it falls into two great halves: judgment and the Assyrian crisis in chapters 1 to 39, and comfort and the coming Servant in chapters 40 to 66. The first chapter works as a summary of the whole.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear, O heavens, and give ear, O earth; for the LORD has spoken: Children have I reared and brought up, but they have rebelled against me" (1:2).
2. "The ox knows its owner, and the donkey its master's crib, but Israel does not know, my people do not understand" (1:3).
3. "Bring no more vain offerings; incense is an abomination to me" (1:13).
4. "Learn to do good; seek justice, correct oppression; bring justice to the fatherless, plead the widow's cause" (1:17).
5. "Come now, let us reason together, says the LORD: though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow" (1:18).
6. "How the faithful city has become a whore" (1:21).

7. “He shall judge between the nations, and shall decide disputes for many peoples; and they shall beat their swords into plowshares” (2:4).

8. “Stop regarding man in whose nostrils is breath, for of what account is he?” (2:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The prophet opens with God calling heaven and earth as witnesses, as in Deuteronomy. The charge is rebellion by children who have been loved and raised. The comparison is humbling: an ox and a donkey know where their food comes from, but Israel does not. The nation is sick from head to foot, with wounds that no one has treated. They are like Sodom, spared only because a few survived.

The religion of the people is another problem. They keep the feasts, offer the sacrifices, spread out their hands in prayer. And God says he cannot stand it. This does not mean God rejects worship. It means worship from people who plot evil and ignore the oppressed is an offense. Hosea 6:6 and Micah 6:8, which you just read, say the same. The remedy is practical: learn to do good, seek justice, correct oppression, defend the fatherless, plead for the widow.

Then comes one of the great invitations in the Bible. “Come now, let us reason together.” God does not simply condemn. He argues, he offers, and he promises. “Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow.” The cleansing that no sacrifice by itself could provide is offered freely, on the condition that they are willing and obedient. The choice is plain: eat the good of the land, or be devoured by the sword.

Chapter 2 sets a vision of the last days beside the failure of the present. The nations will stream to the mountain of the LORD, as in Micah 4. Then the prophet turns to the pride of Judah: idols, wealth, horses, and haughty looks. God will humble all that is lofty. The day of the LORD is against everything proud. Chapter 3 describes the collapse of social order, with children as leaders and women of Zion strutting in finery that will be replaced by sackcloth.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quoted Isaiah’s description of hollow worship: “This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me” (Mark 7:6, from Isaiah 29:13). Revelation 7:14 speaks of those whose robes have been washed in the blood of the Lamb and made white. 1 John 1:7-9 promises that the blood of Jesus cleanses us from all sin. James 1:27 defines pure religion as visiting orphans and widows in their affliction.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Isaiah 1:18 and take it as a personal invitation. Name a sin that you carry, and bring it to God.

Choose one act of justice or mercy this week: help a widow, a child, or someone who is being treated unfairly.

Examine your worship. Is there any area where your religious activity is not matched by how you live?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have rebelled as one of God's children.
- Ask him to reason with you and wash your sins white.
- Thank him for his invitation to come.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 381 · WEEK 55

Isaiah 4:1-5:30

The Branch of the LORD; the vineyard song

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 4:1-5:30. A beautiful promise of the Branch of the LORD is followed by the famous song of the vineyard. Read the song as a story, and notice how the listeners are caught by it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 4 closes the first section of Isaiah with a picture of a cleansed Jerusalem after judgment. Chapter 5 opens with a love song that suddenly turns into a lawsuit. Isaiah probably sang or recited it publicly at a feast. The vineyard, a common image for Israel, appears again and again in Scripture, in the Psalms (like Psalm 80, in two days), and in Jesus' parables.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In that day the branch of the LORD shall be beautiful and glorious" (4:2).
2. "And he who is left in Zion and remains in Jerusalem will be called holy" (4:3).
3. "Then the LORD will create over the whole site of Mount Zion and over her assemblies a cloud by day, and smoke and the shining of a flaming fire by night" (4:5).
4. "Let me sing for my beloved my love song concerning his vineyard" (5:1).
5. "He dug it and cleared it of stones, and planted it with choice vines" (5:2).
6. "What more was there to do for my vineyard, that I have not done in it? When I looked for it to yield grapes, why did it yield wild grapes?" (5:4).
7. "He looked for justice, but behold, bloodshed; for righteousness, but behold, an outcry!" (5:7).

8 “Woe to those who call evil good and good evil, who put darkness for light and light for darkness” (5:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 begins with a bleak scene: seven women clinging to one man because the men have died in war. It shows the depth of the coming loss. Then comes the promise. “The branch of the LORD” will be beautiful and glorious. The word “branch” (Hebrew tsemach) is a title that will later become a name for the Messiah (Jeremiah 23:5; Zechariah 3:8). The survivors of Zion will be called holy. God will wash away the filth and cleanse the bloodstains. And he will cover the city with a canopy of cloud and fire, just as he did in the wilderness. After judgment, a new exodus.

Chapter 5 is a masterpiece of rhetoric. Isaiah sings of a friend who owned a vineyard on a fertile hill. He dug, cleared, planted choice vines, built a watchtower and a winepress. Everything necessary was done. And the vineyard produced wild grapes, sour and useless. The listeners must have enjoyed the song and probably sided with the owner. Then Isaiah turns the question on them: “What more was there to do?” The listeners are the vineyard. God looked for justice, and found bloodshed. He looked for righteousness and heard the cry of the oppressed.

The consequences are given: God will remove the hedge, break down the wall, and let it be trampled. The judgment is the withdrawal of protection. The following six woes detail the sins: greedy land accumulation, drunken feasting, mocking God’s plan, calling evil good, pride in one’s own wisdom, and bribery. Verse 20 is among the most relevant in the whole book. When a society reverses its moral categories, it is ripe for judgment.

The passage ends with the sound of a distant army. God whistles for Assyria from the ends of the earth. It is a dark picture. But the reader knows from chapter 4 that this is not the last word. The Branch will come.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his own vineyard parable of the wicked tenants who killed the owner’s son (Mark 12:1-12), clearly echoing Isaiah 5. In John 15:1-8 he says, “I am the true vine,” the faithful Israel who bears fruit. Jeremiah 23:5 and Zechariah 6:12 call the Messiah the Branch. Galatians 5:22-23 describes the fruit of the Spirit, the good grapes that God wants.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what kind of fruit your life is bearing. Is it justice, mercy, and righteousness, or sour grapes?

Notice where our culture calls evil good and good evil. Pray for clarity and courage.

Thank God for the Branch, Jesus, who is the true vine, and ask to abide in him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the wild grapes you have produced.
- Ask Jesus, the true vine, to help you abide and bear fruit.
- Thank God for all he has done for his vineyard.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 382 · WEEK 55

Psalm 80

Restore us, O God, the vine brought out of Egypt

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 80. It is a prayer of the northern tribes for restoration, and its image of the vine echoes Isaiah 5. Notice the refrain that returns three times, each time with a fuller name for God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 80 is a psalm of Asaph set to the tune "Lilies, a Testimony." It names the northern tribes Ephraim, Benjamin, and Manasseh, and so was probably written around the fall of the northern kingdom. It is placed here to answer Isaiah's vineyard song. Isaiah says the vineyard produced wild grapes. The psalmist asks the vinedresser to come back and tend it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O Shepherd of Israel, you who lead Joseph like a flock" (v. 1).
2. "Restore us, O God; let your face shine, that we may be saved!" (v. 3).
3. "O LORD God of hosts, how long will you be angry with your people's prayers?" (v. 4).
4. "You have fed them with the bread of tears and given them tears to drink in full measure" (v. 5).
5. "You brought a vine out of Egypt; you drove out the nations and planted it" (v. 8).
6. "Why then have you broken down its walls, so that all who pass along the way pluck its fruit?" (v. 12).
7. "Turn again, O God of hosts! Look down from heaven, and see; have regard for this vine" (v. 14).

8 “But let your hand be on the man of your right hand, the son of man whom you have made strong for yourself!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the image of a shepherd and moves to the image of a vine. In both, God is the caretaker of his people. The psalmist reminds him of what he did: he brought a vine out of Egypt, cleared the ground, and let it take root until it filled the land. The vine reached from the mountains to the sea. Then the walls fell, and the vine was burned and cut down. This is Isaiah 5 from the other side. Isaiah says the vine did not bear fruit. The psalmist pleads that God would not abandon it.

The refrain is the heart of the prayer. It appears three times, with the name of God growing. “Restore us, O God” (v. 3). “Restore us, O God of hosts” (v. 7). “Restore us, O LORD God of hosts” (v. 19). Each time the same request: “Let your face shine, that we may be saved.” As the prayer deepens, the psalmist uses a fuller and more covenantal name. It is the language of someone who is coming closer to God as they pray.

Notice that the psalmist does not ask for the nation to reform itself. He asks God to restore. The people cannot fix their own spiritual condition. “Let your face shine” is the old priestly blessing of Numbers 6. Salvation is the shining of God’s face.

Verse 17 introduces a mysterious figure: “the man of your right hand, the son of man whom you have made strong.” Perhaps this is the king, or Israel as God’s son. But the language points beyond them. The vine needs a representative who will do what the vine failed to do. The psalm ends with a vow: “Then we shall not turn back from you; give us life, and we will call upon your name.” Renewal produces faithfulness.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the true vine” (John 15:1), the faithful Israel who bears fruit and in whom we are branches. “The son of man at God’s right hand” is a title Jesus used of himself (Mark 14:62; Daniel 7:13). Hebrews 1:3 says he sits at the right hand of the Majesty. 2 Corinthians 4:6 says God has shone in our hearts “to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray the refrain “Restore us, O God; let your face shine, that we may be saved” for yourself and for your church.

Think about an area of your life that has been “broken down.” Ask God to restore it.

Thank God that the true vine, Jesus, bears all the fruit that Israel did not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask the Shepherd of Israel to restore you where you are ruined.
- Ask him to let his face shine on you.
- Thank him for the man at his right hand.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

“Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel.”

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 383 · WEEK 55

Psalm 81

I am the LORD your God, if only my people would listen

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 81. It is a festival psalm in which God himself speaks and pleads with his people. Notice how it moves from joyful praise to a wistful "if only."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 81 is a psalm of Asaph, to be sung at a festival, probably the Feast of Tabernacles or Passover, as it refers to the new moon and the full moon. The people are called to celebrate. Then, in verse 5, the voice shifts, and God himself speaks. The psalm pairs with Psalm 80: there the people asked God to restore them, and here God asks them why they will not listen.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Sing aloud to God our strength; shout for joy to the God of Jacob!" (v. 1).
2. "I relieved your shoulder of the burden; your hands were freed from the basket" (v. 6).
3. "In distress you called, and I delivered you" (v. 7).
4. "Hear, O my people, while I admonish you! O Israel, if you would but listen to me!" (v. 8).
5. "There shall be no strange god among you; you shall not bow down to a foreign god" (v. 9).
6. "I am the LORD your God, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt. Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it" (v. 10).
7. "But my people did not listen to my voice; Israel would not submit to me" (v. 11).
8. "Oh, that my people would listen to me, that Israel would walk in my ways! … I would feed you with the finest of the wheat, and with honey from the rock I would satisfy you" (vv. 13, 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first part of the psalm is exuberant. Musical instruments are named: tambourine, lyre, harp, trumpet. The people are told to celebrate because it is a statute for Israel. Worship is an obligation, and it is also a delight.

Then God speaks, and the voice is full of pathos. He reminds them of the exodus: he relieved their shoulders of the burden, freed their hands from the baskets of brick-making, and answered them in the thunder. He tested them at the waters of Meribah. The history is in the background of everything that follows.

God's central appeal is verse 8: "Hear, O my people." It echoes the Shema of Deuteronomy 6. The first commandment follows: no strange god among you. And then a promise that is also an invitation: "Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it." Like a baby bird with its beak open, the people are invited to depend on their provider. God is not reluctant. He has more to give than they dare ask.

The sad part comes in verse 11. "But my people did not listen to my voice." So God "gave them over to their stubborn hearts, to follow their own counsels." Sometimes the worst judgment is to be left to what we want.

The psalm ends with God's wistful "if only." If they would listen, if they would walk in his ways, he would subdue their enemies and feed them with the finest wheat and honey from the rock. This is God's heart. He does not delight in judgment. He longs for his people to listen and to receive his blessings.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28), the same relief of burdens. John 6:35 says he is the bread of life, the finest wheat. 1 Corinthians 10:4 says that the rock in the wilderness was Christ, from whom flowed the water, and in Psalm 81 the honey. Luke 13:34 echoes the divine longing: "How often would I have gathered your children… and you would not!" Revelation 3:20 shows Christ knocking at the door.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where God is saying "if only you would listen" to you. What is he asking that you have not done?

Open your mouth wide. Bring a large request to God this week, a need for yourself or for others.

Thank God for the burdens he has lifted from your shoulders.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Shout to God for his strength, and tell him why.
- Confess where you have not listened to his voice.
- Ask him to open your ears.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 384 · WEEK 55

Isaiah 6:1-8:22

Isaiah's call; Immanuel, God with us

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 6:1-8:22. Chapter 6 is the call vision, one of the most important scenes in the Bible. Read it slowly, then continue into chapter 7, where Isaiah gives King Ahaz the sign of Immanuel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah has a vision of God in the year King Uzziah died, about 740 BC. Uzziah had reigned for fifty-two years, a time of stability, and his death left a sense of insecurity. In chapters 7 and 8, the setting shifts to the crisis of 734 BC, when Syria and Israel allied against Judah and threatened King Ahaz. Isaiah goes out to meet Ahaz and offers him a sign.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the year that King Uzziah died I saw the Lord sitting upon a throne, high and lifted up; and the train of his robe filled the temple" (6:1).
2. "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!" (6:3).
3. "Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips" (6:5).
4. "Behold, this has touched your lips; your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for" (6:7).
5. "Here I am! Send me" (6:8).
6. "If you are not firm in faith, you will not be firm at all" (7:9).
7. "Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel" (7:14).

8 “To the teaching and to the testimony! If they will not speak according to this word, it is because they have no light of dawn” (8:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Isaiah’s vision is the pattern of all true encounters with God. First, God is seen in majesty: seated on a throne, the hem of his robe filling the temple. Seraphim cover their faces and their feet and cry, “Holy, holy, holy.” The threefold repetition is the strongest superlative in Hebrew. Holiness is the one attribute of God that is repeated this way in Scripture. It means that God is utterly set apart, pure, and other. The doorposts shake and the house fills with smoke.

Second, the response is a recognition of sin. “Woe is me! For I am lost.” Isaiah, a respected man, a prophet who had already pronounced woes on others, now sees himself. The nearer one comes to God’s holiness, the clearer one’s own uncleanness becomes.

Third, there is cleansing. A seraph takes a burning coal from the altar and touches his mouth: “Your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for.” Isaiah does not clean himself. God provides the atonement, through the altar, a picture of sacrifice.

Fourth, the commission. Only now does God ask, “Whom shall I send?” And Isaiah, forgiven, says, “Here I am! Send me.” Service follows grace. The message he is given is a hard one: the people will hear and not understand, until the land is laid waste. Yet “the holy seed” is the stump that remains.

In chapter 7 the lesson is applied to a king. Ahaz is afraid. Isaiah tells him to be calm and trust. When Ahaz refuses to ask for a sign, with a pious excuse, God gives one anyway: a virgin will conceive and bear a son, Immanuel, “God with us.” In the immediate setting, a child would be born as a sign that the enemy kings would fall before he grew up. Yet the language reaches beyond. The promise is that God himself will be with his people.

STEP 5

Connection

John 12:41 says that Isaiah saw Jesus’ glory and spoke of him. Matthew 1:22-23 quotes Isaiah 7:14 as fulfilled in the virgin birth of Jesus. Revelation 4:8 echoes the seraphim, “Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty.” Romans 10:15 asks, “How are they to preach unless they are sent?” 1 Peter 2:8 quotes Isaiah 8:14 about the stone of stumbling.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes in silence before God's holiness. Let it correct how small your view of him has been.

Confess one sin by name, and receive the cleansing God has provided in Christ.

Pray Isaiah's words, "Here I am! Send me," and ask where God may be sending you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as holy, holy, holy, in your own words.
- Confess your unclean lips, and thank him for taking away your guilt.
- Tell him, "Here I am," and listen.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 385 · WEEK 55

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 7:14 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

REST

Meditation

Ahaz, king of Judah, was afraid. Two armies were marching against him, and Isaiah met him with an offer: ask for any sign you like, as deep as Sheol or as high as heaven. Ahaz refused with a pious-sounding excuse. He had already decided to trust Assyria instead of God. So the Lord gave a sign anyway.

"The Lord himself will give you a sign." It is a gift that is given whether or not it is asked for. Grace often works like that. God gives more than we ask and sometimes more than we deserve.

"Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son." In Isaiah's time, a young woman would bear a child, and before he was old enough to know right from wrong, the threat from the northern kings would be gone. Matthew, writing under the Spirit's guidance, sees a deeper meaning. The sign finds its full meaning in Mary and the birth of Jesus, born of a virgin.

“And shall call his name Immanuel.” The name means “God with us.” It is the whole message of the gospel in two words. God has not stayed at a distance. He has come near, in flesh, in the middle of our fear and trouble. Ahaz needed to know that God was with him. We need to know it too.

Say this verse when you are afraid. The promise is not that every threat will vanish, but that God is with you. In Christ, the one who is called Immanuel has promised, “I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the unit that surrounds the Assyrian crisis. You read of Hezekiah’s trust in the LORD when Sennacherib’s army stood outside Jerusalem, and of his later pride when he showed the Babylonian envoys his treasures. You entered the book of Isaiah, with the courtroom scene of chapter 1 and its great invitation, “Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow.” You read the song of the vineyard, in which God looked for justice and found bloodshed, and you prayed Psalms 80 and 81 for the vine to be restored and for the people to listen. And you stood in the temple with Isaiah, saw the Holy One high and lifted up, heard the cry of “Holy, holy, holy,” and received the sign of Immanuel. The week taught that God is holy, that he provides his own cleansing, and that he is with his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah saw God’s holiness and was undone, then cleansed, then sent. Where are you in that pattern right now?

Jesus is the true vine who bears the fruit Israel never did. What would it look like to abide in him this week?

Immanuel means “God with us.” Where do you most need to remember that he is with you right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for Immanuel, God with us.

Ask him to cleanse you, send you, and be with you.

Rest in his presence.

DAY 386 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 6:1-7; 1 Peter 1:14-16

The holiness of God

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Doctrine · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 6:1-7 again, then turn to 1 Peter 1:14-16. Today is a doctrinal pause, so you are reading two passages together: Isaiah's vision of the Holy One and Peter's command that God's people be holy. Ask as you read: what is holiness, and what does it have to do with me?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah saw the Lord on a throne in the temple, and the seraphim cried, "Holy, holy, holy." Seven centuries later, the apostle Peter wrote to scattered believers who were living as strangers in a pagan world, and he took a command from Leviticus: "You shall be holy, for I am holy." Between them stands the central idea of the whole Bible. This is a day to stop and think carefully about what it means to say God is holy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!" (Isaiah 6:3).
2. The foundations of the thresholds shook at the voice, and the house was filled with smoke (Isaiah 6:4).
3. "Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips" (Isaiah 6:5).
4. "Your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for" (Isaiah 6:7).
5. "As obedient children, do not be conformed to the passions of your former ignorance" (1 Peter 1:14).
6. "But as he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct" (1 Peter 1:15).

7. “Since it is written, You shall be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:16).

8. The holiness commanded is rooted in the holiness of the one who calls.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

To say that God is holy is to say first that he is different. The Hebrew word means “set apart” or “cut off.” God is not part of creation. He is not a bigger version of us. He is the Creator, infinitely above everything he has made, in power, in knowledge, in being. When the seraphim cover their faces and feet, they show that even the highest created beings cannot look at him without reverence.

Holiness also means that God is morally pure. In him there is no darkness at all (1 John 1:5). He cannot tolerate evil, and he cannot be tempted by it. This is why Isaiah’s response to the vision was not delight but terror. In the presence of perfect purity, his own uncleanness was exposed. Holiness is not a cold attribute alone. It is bound up with God’s love, justice, and mercy. His love is a holy love, and his justice is a holy justice. This is why forgiveness is costly: a holy God cannot simply look away from sin. He deals with it, and he does so by providing atonement. The coal on the altar points to a sacrifice.

Third, holiness is shared. God does not remain in splendid isolation. He calls his people to be holy, as Peter says, in all their conduct. This is what it means to be saved: to be set apart for God, and to be changed to be like him. We are not holy by our own effort. In Christ, believers are already declared holy (1 Corinthians 1:2), and yet we are called to become holy in practice. Holiness is a gift we receive and a goal we pursue by the Spirit.

The right response to a holy God is reverence, repentance, and worship. And the good news is that the holy God has made a way to come near.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Put the two passages side by side and they teach a unified lesson. Isaiah’s vision shows us the God who is holy. Peter’s command shows us what holiness means for those who belong to him. Neither is possible without the other.

Isaiah’s experience follows an order: vision, confession, cleansing, and service. He did not choose to confess. The sight of God’s holiness did that for him. And the cleansing was not earned. The seraph brought the coal from the altar, and the declaration was made: “Your guilt is taken away.” Holiness begins with God’s initiative.

Peter writes to Christians who were tempted to go back to their old way of life. He tells them not to be conformed to the passions of their former ignorance. They once lived without knowing God. Now they have been called by a holy God, and they are to be holy. The command is based on the character of the one who calls. He does not say, be holy because it is difficult and noble. He says, be holy because I am.

The surrounding verses explain the foundation. Holiness comes from knowing that we have been ransomed "with the precious blood of Christ." The holiness that God requires is the holiness that he has paid for. We are not trying to become acceptable. We have been made acceptable, and we now live out what is true of us.

This changes how we think about the Christian life. It is not mainly a list of rules but a way of life that reflects the character of the God we have met. We look at him, and we begin to be changed into the same image.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:14 says, "Strive for peace with everyone, and for the holiness without which no one will see the Lord." Hebrews 10:10 says we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ. 2 Corinthians 3:18 says we are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. 1 Thessalonians 4:7 says God has called us to holiness. Revelation 4:8 shows the living creatures still crying "Holy, holy, holy" before the throne.

STEP 6

Application

Take five minutes to sit before God without asking for anything. Let the word "holy" fill your mind.

Choose one area of life where your conduct does not reflect the God who called you. Ask for the Spirit's help to change.

Thank God that holiness is first something he gives, in Christ, and not something you must earn.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for his holiness, and tell him how it moves you.

Thank him for taking away your guilt through Christ.

Ask him to make you holy as he is holy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 387 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 9:1-12:6

The child born to us; the shoot of Jesse; peaceable kingdom

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 83 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 9:1-12:6. These chapters contain the great Messianic promises of Isaiah: the child born to us, the shoot from the stump of Jesse, and the peaceable kingdom. Read them as light dawning in a dark place.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 8 ended in darkness and distress, with a people who consult mediums and find only gloom. Chapter 9 begins with a "but." The land of Zebulun and Naphtali, the first to be devastated by Assyria, will be the first to see light. In these chapters, Isaiah gives his most famous portrait of the coming king, and promises that after the Assyrian axe comes a shoot from the stump of David's family.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light; those who dwelt in a land of deep darkness, on them has light shone" (9:2).
2. "For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder" (9:6).
3. "And his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace" (9:6).
4. "Of the increase of his government and of peace there will be no end" (9:7).
5. "For all this his anger has not turned away, and his hand is stretched out still" (9:12).
6. "There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit" (11:1).

7. “The Spirit of the LORD shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding” (11:2).

8. “The wolf shall dwell with the lamb… for the earth will be full of the knowledge of the LORD as the waters cover the sea” (11:6, 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The light in chapter 9 is a reversal. Isaiah says the very place that first suffered under Assyria will be honored. Galilee, a region in the far north that was despised, becomes the setting for the good news. The prophecy then explains why: a child is born. The one who comes is a human child, born into the line of David, and yet his names point beyond the human. “Mighty God” and “Everlasting Father” are titles that no merely human king could carry. “Wonderful Counselor” means that he needs no advice, and “Prince of Peace” means that he brings wholeness. His government will have no end, and it will rest on justice and righteousness.

Notice the phrase, “The zeal of the LORD of hosts will do this.” God himself is committed to accomplishing it. Yet the rest of chapter 9 and chapter 10 describe the judgment that comes first. Assyria is God’s axe, used to chop down his own people, but then judged for its pride. The tool that boasts against its maker will be broken. “Shall the axe boast over him who hews with it?”

Chapter 11 returns to hope. The Assyrian army is described as a forest cut down, but a shoot comes from the stump of Jesse. The picture is of a royal family reduced to a stump after the fall of David’s line, and yet life springs from it. Upon him rests the Spirit in sevenfold fullness. He judges the poor with righteousness. And his reign restores creation itself: the wolf with the lamb, the leopard with the young goat, a child leading them. The cause is that “the earth will be full of the knowledge of the LORD as the waters cover the sea.”

Chapter 12 ends the section with a song. “Behold, God is my salvation; I will trust, and will not be afraid.” “With joy you will draw water from the wells of salvation.” The proper response to such promises is song.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 4:12-16 quotes Isaiah 9:1-2 and says that Jesus began his ministry in Galilee. Luke 1:32-33 echoes Isaiah 9:7 in the angel’s announcement to Mary. Revelation 5:5 calls Jesus the Root of David, and Romans 15:12 quotes Isaiah 11:10. At his baptism the Spirit rested on Jesus (Matthew 3:16). Romans 8:19-21 speaks of creation itself being set free. John 7:37-38 recalls the wells of salvation.

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 9:6 aloud and pause on each of the four names. Which one do you most need today?

Think about a dark place in your life or community. Pray for light to shine there.

Sing or read Isaiah 12:2 as a prayer of trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the light that has dawned on you.

Praise the child as Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.

Ask him to bring his peace where you are.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 388 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 13:1-17:14

Oracles against Babylon, Assyria, Philistia, Moab [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 86 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 13:1-17:14. This is a survey day. These chapters contain oracles against Babylon, Assyria, Philistia, Moab, Damascus, and others. Do not worry about every name. Read for the main point: God rules over all the nations.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah's message so far has been to Judah. Now he turns outward. The oracles against the nations make up chapters 13 to 23, and they teach that the God of Israel is not just a tribal deity. He is the judge of all the earth. Babylon and Assyria, the great powers of the day, are included. These oracles also served a purpose for Judah: they showed that trusting in alliances with the nations was foolish, since all of them are under God's judgment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The oracle concerning Babylon which Isaiah the son of Amoz saw" (13:1).
2. "Behold, the day of the LORD comes, cruel, with wrath and fierce anger, to make the land a desolation" (13:9).
3. "I will punish the world for its evil, and the wicked for their iniquity; I will put an end to the pomp of the arrogant" (13:11).
4. "How you are fallen from heaven, O Day Star, son of Dawn! … You said in your heart, I will ascend to heaven" (14:12-13).
5. "This is the purpose that is purposed concerning the whole earth, and this is the hand that is stretched out over all the nations" (14:26).
6. "For the LORD has had compassion on Jacob and will again choose Israel" (14:1).

7. “My heart cries out for Moab” (15:5).
8. “In that day man will look to his Maker, and his eyes will look on the Holy One of Israel” (17:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first oracle is against Babylon, which at this time was not yet the dominant power. Isaiah looks ahead to its rise and fall. The day of the LORD is a day of judgment on pride, “to put an end to the pomp of the arrogant.” Babylon is described as “the glory of kingdoms,” yet it will be like Sodom and Gomorrah, a place for desert animals. In the Bible, Babylon becomes a symbol of human pride and organized rebellion against God, from the tower of Babel to the book of Revelation.

The taunt against the king of Babylon in chapter 14 is one of the most striking passages in Isaiah. The king is addressed as “Day Star, son of Dawn,” who tried to ascend to heaven and set his throne above the stars of God. He is brought down to Sheol. Christian tradition has often read this passage as describing Satan’s fall, and the pattern of pride that leads to a fall certainly applies. In its original setting, it is a mocking song about a tyrant whose arrogance ended in the grave. Either way, the lesson is the same. Whoever exalts himself will be humbled.

Notice that in the middle of the judgment, Isaiah describes God’s compassion on Jacob. God’s justice toward the nations is connected to his faithfulness to his people. And the purpose is “purposed concerning the whole earth.” History is not random. God has a plan, and none can annul it.

Even in the oracle against Moab, Isaiah weeps. “My heart cries out for Moab.” The prophet is not gleeful about judgment. And Damascus, Ephraim, and the others show the same: trust in human alliances will fail. In the day of judgment, people will “look to their Maker.” Some will turn to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven” (Luke 10:18). Revelation 18 describes the fall of Babylon the great, and Revelation 17 shows its pride. Daniel 4:30-37 shows Nebuchadnezzar humbled. James 4:6 says, “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.” Acts 17:26-27 says God made every nation and determined their times and boundaries. Ezekiel 33:11 shows that God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked.

STEP 6

Application

Look at the news and remember that God rules the nations. Pray for a nation that is in turmoil.

Examine yourself for the pride expressed in “I will ascend.” Where do you want to be on top?

Weep for someone you might be tempted to judge, as Isaiah did for Moab.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as ruler of all nations.
- Ask him to humble pride in you.
- Pray for a nation in turmoil.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

“For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.”

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 389 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 18:1-23:18

Oracles against the nations continue [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 105 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 18:1-23:18. This is another survey day. The oracles continue against Cush, Egypt, Babylon, Edom, Arabia, Jerusalem, and Tyre. Look for the repeated message: do not put your trust in the nations.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The oracles against the nations continue. Judah was tempted to look to Egypt and Cush (Ethiopia) for protection against Assyria, and Isaiah repeatedly warns against it. One of the strangest passages in the book appears in chapter 20, where Isaiah walks naked and barefoot for three years as a sign of what would happen to Egypt and Cush. Chapter 22 turns the oracles back toward Jerusalem itself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In that time a present will be brought to the LORD of hosts from a people tall and smooth-skinned” (18:7).
2. “The LORD will strike Egypt, striking and healing, and they will return to the LORD, and he will listen to their pleas” (19:22).
3. “Blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work of my hands, and Israel my inheritance” (19:25).
4. “Thus shall it be with the nations in which we hoped… and how shall we escape?” (20:6).
5. “Watchman, what time of the night?” (21:11).
6. “You were not looking to him who did it, or have regard for him who planned it long ago” (22:11).

7. “And I will place on his shoulder the key of the house of David” (22:22).
8. “Her merchandise and her wages will be holy to the LORD” (23:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The oracles of these chapters appear dry, but they carry a thread of astonishing hope. Egypt, the old oppressor of Israel, will be struck by the LORD and then healed. In chapter 19, there is a vision of a day when Egypt will speak the language of Canaan, build an altar to the LORD, and cry out to him. He will send them a savior, and they will know him. And then the climax: “Blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work of my hands, and Israel my inheritance.” Three nations, former enemies, become a blessing in the midst of the earth. The gospel of God’s mercy for the nations is already in the Old Testament.

The oracle of chapter 20 is bizarre but purposeful. Isaiah’s three years of walking naked and barefoot is a sermon without words: this is how the Egyptians and Ethiopians will be led away by Assyria. Those who relied on them will say, “Where can we escape?” It was designed to make Judah afraid of putting hope in the wrong place.

Chapter 22 is the oracle about Jerusalem, “the valley of vision.” The city celebrates when it should mourn. People prepare their defenses, store water, fortify the walls, and count houses, but “you did not look to him who did it.” They prepared everything but did not seek God. The result is a dreadful motto: “Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die.” Paul quotes it in 1 Corinthians 15:32. The chapter also contains the story of Shebna, a proud steward replaced by Eliakim, who receives “the key of the house of David.” He can open, and none can shut.

The last oracle, against Tyre, ends with a surprise: her profits will be set apart for the LORD. The nations are not simply doomed. Some are redeemed.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 3:7 speaks of Christ as the one “who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut.” Acts 8:26-40 records an Ethiopian official coming to faith. Ephesians 2:13-14 says that those who were far off have been brought near. Galatians 3:8 says the gospel was preached beforehand to Abraham: “In you shall all the nations be blessed.” Revelation 21:24 pictures the nations bringing their glory into the city.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you trusting in something other than God for security: a job, savings, relationships, a plan?

Pray for a nation or group you would not usually pray for, including those who have been enemies.

Remember that the keys of the kingdom are in the hands of Jesus, and bring a closed door to him in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you look to Egypt, to people or things, for help.
- Pray for the nations to be brought into his kingdom.
- Thank him that his plan stands.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 390 · WEEK 56

Psalm 75

At the set time I will judge with equity

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 75. It is a short psalm in which God speaks about his appointed time to judge. Notice how the psalm moves between praise, a divine oracle, and the psalmist's response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 75 is a psalm of Asaph, set to the tune "Do Not Destroy." It likely belongs to the time of the Assyrian crisis. The people are surrounded by arrogant powers, and the question is when God will act. The answer comes in a divine oracle: God has an appointed time, and he will judge with equity. It is a good companion to the oracles against the nations you have just read.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "We give thanks to you, O God; we give thanks, for your name is near" (v. 1).
2. "At the set time that I appoint I will judge with equity" (v. 2).
3. "When the earth totters, and all its inhabitants, it is I who keep steady its pillars" (v. 3).
4. "I say to the boastful, Do not boast, and to the wicked, Do not lift up your horn" (v. 4).
5. "Do not lift up your horn on high, or speak with haughty neck" (v. 5).
6. "For not from the east or from the west and not from the wilderness comes lifting up" (v. 6).
7. "But it is God who executes judgment, putting down one and lifting up another" (v. 7).
8. "All the horns of the wicked I will cut off, but the horns of the righteous shall be lifted up" (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with thanks. The strange thing is that the thanks come before the judgment. The psalmist is confident that God is near, and he can give thanks in advance. This is the posture of faith. We thank God not only for what he has done but for what he is going to do.

Then God speaks: "At the set time that I appoint I will judge with equity." Two things are stressed. First, God has a schedule. Judgment is not rushed or delayed by accident. It will come at the right moment, when he decides. People often think that because judgment is delayed, it will never come. The psalm says it will. Second, God judges with equity. He does not act capriciously. His judgment is perfectly fair.

When the earth totters and the foundations seem to shake, God says it is he who steadies its pillars. In the Assyrian crisis, with kingdoms collapsing, the world seemed unstable. The psalm assures us that the stability of the world rests on God.

Then the oracle addresses the arrogant: do not boast, do not lift up your horn. The horn is a symbol of strength and pride. The proud think they can raise themselves. But "not from the east or from the west… comes lifting up." No human direction offers promotion. "It is God who executes judgment, putting down one and lifting up another." Everything depends on him.

The cup in verse 8 is a cup of wrath. The wicked of the earth will drink it to the dregs. Against that, the psalmist says: "I will declare it forever; I will sing praises to the God of Jacob." The final verse contrasts the horns of the wicked, which will be cut off, with the horns of the righteous, which will be lifted up.

STEP 5

Connection

Mary's song says, "He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate" (Luke 1:52). Jesus said that those who exalt themselves will be humbled, and those who humble themselves will be exalted (Luke 14:11). 1 Peter 5:6 says, "Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you." Jesus drank the cup of God's wrath on the cross (Mark 14:36).

STEP 6

Application

If you are tempted to boast, remember that all lifting up comes from God.

If you are waiting for justice, trust God's set time, and give thanks in advance.

Pray for stability for those whose world is shaking.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for being near.
- Ask him to keep you from boasting.
- Thank him that he judges with equity.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 391 · WEEK 56

Psalm 76

In Judah God is known

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 76. It is a victory song for Zion, probably written after the Assyrian army was destroyed outside Jerusalem. Imagine the people singing it in the temple after the night the camp fell silent.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 76 is a psalm of Asaph. Its mention of "Salem" and "Zion" places it in Jerusalem, and its description of warriors who "found not use of their hands" fits what happened to Sennacherib's army in 2 Kings 19:35, when the angel of the LORD struck down 185,000 men in one night. You read this psalm once in Unit 8, where the focus was on God's presence. Here, hear it as the song after the Assyrian crisis.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In Judah God is known; his name is great in Israel" (v. 1).
2. "His abode has been established in Salem, his dwelling place in Zion" (v. 2).
3. "There he broke the flashing arrows, the shield, the sword, and the weapons of war" (v. 3).
4. "The stouthearted were stripped of their spoil; they sank into sleep; all the men of war were unable to use their hands" (v. 5).
5. "At your rebuke, O God of Jacob, both rider and horse lay stunned" (v. 6).
6. "But you, you are to be feared! Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?" (v. 7).

7. “From the heavens you uttered judgment; the earth feared and was still, when God arose to establish judgment, to save all the humble of the earth” (vv. 8-9).

8. “Make vows to the LORD your God and perform them; let all around him bring gifts to him who is to be feared” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a claim. In Judah God is known. This is a statement about revelation. Other nations had their gods, but the LORD made himself known in a specific people and place. His dwelling is in Zion, and from there he reveals who he is.

The picture of verse 3 is a victory without a battle on Judah’s side. The arrows, the shield, the sword are broken “there,” at Jerusalem. The enemy soldiers were stripped of their spoil and sank into sleep, the sleep of death. The mighty are helpless. The psalm does not mention Judah’s army. It was God’s victory. “At your rebuke… both rider and horse lay stunned.” In the Assyrian camp, with their chariots and horsemen, nothing was left.

The turning point is the question in verse 7: “Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?” It is not a question about the Assyrian army only. It is a question for everyone. No one can stand before God’s anger. And yet, the same verse of judgment has a purpose: “to save all the humble of the earth.” God’s judgment is a rescue for those who are oppressed. The wrath of man shall praise him, the psalm says, and the survivors of wrath will be restrained.

The psalm then calls for a response. Make vows and keep them. Bring gifts to the one to be feared. The proper response to a God who is awesome is worship and fulfilling our promises to him. And the final line is a warning to the powerful: “He cuts off the spirit of princes; he is to be feared by the kings of the earth.”

For Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem, this psalm was a testimony. The God of whom Isaiah spoke had done what he said.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the gates of hell will not prevail against his church (Matthew 16:18). Revelation 19:11-16 shows a victorious king on a white horse. Colossians 2:15 says Christ disarmed the rulers and authorities and made a public spectacle of them. Zephaniah 3:17 says the LORD is mighty to save. Romans 12:1 invites us to make our own offering. Hebrews 12:28-29 says our God is a consuming fire and calls for reverence.

STEP 6

Application

Think about a situation in which you were rescued without doing anything. Give thanks for it.

Keep a vow you have made to God and neglected.

Take comfort that God saves “all the humble of the earth.” Choose humility today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Stand in awe of God’s name and power.

Thank him for saving the humble.

Tell him a vow you want to keep.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

“For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.”

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 392 · WEEK 56

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 9:6 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

REST

Meditation

This verse is among the best loved in the Bible, and it is easy to hear it as only a Christmas carol. Read it today as Isaiah's first hearers did, in a time of fear and darkness.

"For to us a child is born." The Messiah will be truly human, born into the world as every child is. "To us a son is given." He is a gift. The first phrase says what he is, a real child. The second says where he comes from, a gift from God. He is both fully one of us and given to us from above.

"The government shall be upon his shoulder." A child with the weight of the world's government on his shoulder. In the ancient world, the key or the robe of office was worn on the shoulder. The one who rules is the child. It is a paradox that the New Testament unfolds, a king born in a manger, who rules from a cross.

Then four names. “Wonderful Counselor” means that he has wisdom beyond ours, and that he never gives bad advice. “Mighty God” means that he is not merely human. He is God, the divine warrior. “Everlasting Father” means that he cares for his people with a father’s love and does so forever. “Prince of Peace” means that he is the source of wholeness, and the reconciler between God and man.

Say the names slowly. Choose one that you most need today. If you are confused, he is your Counselor. If you are afraid, he is the Mighty God. If you feel alone, he is the Everlasting Father. If you are anxious or divided, he is your Prince of Peace.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the oracles of Isaiah’s first section. You read the great promises of the Messiah: the light in Galilee, the child born to us, the shoot from Jesse’s stump, and the kingdom where the earth is filled with the knowledge of the LORD. You took a doctrinal pause on the holiness of God, linking Isaiah’s vision to Peter’s call to be holy. You surveyed the oracles against Babylon, Philistia, Moab, Egypt, Jerusalem, and Tyre, and saw that God rules all the nations and even promises to bless Egypt and Assyria. And you read two psalms of the Assyrian crisis: Psalm 75, on God’s set time to judge, and Psalm 76, a victory song for Zion. The week taught that God is holy, that he rules history, and that he sends a child who will be the Prince of Peace.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God’s holiness means that he is set apart and morally pure. How does that change the way you think of coming to him?

Isaiah 9:6 gives four names for the coming king. Which of these do you most need Jesus to be for you this week, and why?

The oracles against the nations show that God rules all of history. What situation in the world or your own life is easier to face when you remember this?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the child born and the son given.

Pray that his government and peace would grow in your life.

Rest in him as Prince of Peace.

DAY 393 · WEEK 57

Psalm 83

O God, do not keep silence

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 83. It is a prayer against a coalition of enemy nations that plot to wipe Israel off the map. Notice what the psalmist finally asks God to do to the enemies, and why.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 83 is a song of Asaph. It lists ten nations that have conspired against Israel: Edom, the Ishmaelites, Moab, the Hagrites, Gebal, Ammon, Amalek, Philistia, Tyre, and Assyria. The occasion may be one of the great coalitions in Judah's history, such as the one in 2 Chronicles 20. It follows the oracles against the nations: those who plot against God's people will answer to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, do not keep silence; do not hold your peace or be still, O God!" (v. 1).
2. "For behold, your enemies make an uproar; those who hate you have raised their heads" (v. 2).
3. "They lay crafty plans against your people; they consult together against your treasured ones" (v. 3).
4. "They say, Come, let us wipe them out as a nation; let the name of Israel be remembered no more!" (v. 4).
5. "For they conspire with one accord; against you they make a covenant" (v. 5).
6. "Do to them as you did to Midian, as to Sisera and Jabin at the river Kishon" (v. 9).
7. "Fill their faces with shame, that they may seek your name, O LORD" (v. 16).

8 “That they may know that you alone, whose name is the LORD, are the Most High over all the earth” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with an urgent plea that God would not be silent. The psalmist feels that God is quiet while the enemies are loud. This is the common experience of the people of God: the wicked are noisy and active, and God seems to be still. The prayer asks God to speak and act.

The enemies’ plan is genocide. “Come, let us wipe them out as a nation; let the name of Israel be remembered no more!” It is a conspiracy to erase God’s people. Notice the key line in verse 5: “Against you they make a covenant.” The psalmist sees that the attack on Israel is an attack on God. The people are God’s treasured ones, and to threaten them is to threaten him. This is the same logic as Saul on the road to Damascus, who was asked, “Why are you persecuting me?”

The psalmist then recalls past victories: Midian, Sisera, Jabin, Oreb and Zeeb. These were not won by Israel’s strength but by God’s intervention. The memory of past deliverance is the ground of present prayer.

The prayer for judgment uses imagery of fire, wind, and storms: let them be like tumbleweed, like chaff before the wind, like a forest in flames. But look at the purpose. “Fill their faces with shame, that they may seek your name, O LORD.” The aim is not only destruction but conversion. The psalmist wants the enemies to be humbled so that they will seek God. And the final goal is universal: “that they may know that you alone, whose name is the LORD, are the Most High over all the earth.”

This is the true motive of all faithful prayer for justice: the glory of God and the knowing of his name across the earth.

STEP 5

Connection

In Acts 9:4, Jesus asked Saul, “Why are you persecuting me?” Saul, once an enemy, became an apostle, just as the psalm hopes enemies may seek the LORD’s name. Matthew 5:44 commands us to love our enemies and pray for those who persecute us. Philippians 2:10-11 says that every knee will bow and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father. Revelation 11:15 says the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for those who oppose the church, that they would seek the name of the LORD.

Remember a past deliverance and give thanks. Let it support a present prayer.

Pray for the persecuted church by name, if you know a country or region.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what troubles his people today.
- Ask him to act, and to bring his enemies to seek his name.
- Remember what he has done in the past.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 394 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 24:1-27:13

The Isaiah Apocalypse, cosmic judgment and salvation

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 24:1-27:13. These chapters are called the Isaiah Apocalypse. They look beyond the Assyrian crisis to the end of history. Read for the big picture: the whole earth judged, and a feast on the mountain of the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the oracles against individual nations, Isaiah steps back and describes judgment on the whole earth. The language is cosmic, with the earth laid waste, the heavens shaken, and the moon confounded. And in the midst of it, there are songs of praise, a banquet for all peoples, and the promise that death itself will be swallowed up. Though these chapters are difficult, they contain some of the most beautiful promises in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Behold, the LORD will empty the earth and make it desolate, and he will twist its surface and scatter its inhabitants” (24:1).
2. “The earth lies defiled under its inhabitants; for they have transgressed the laws, violated the statutes, broken the everlasting covenant” (24:5).
3. “O LORD, you are my God; I will exalt you; I will praise your name, for you have done wonderful things” (25:1).
4. “On this mountain the LORD of hosts will make for all peoples a feast of rich food, a feast of well-aged wine” (25:6).
5. “He will swallow up death forever; and the Lord GOD will wipe away tears from all faces” (25:8).

6. “You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you” (26:3).
7. “Your dead shall live; their bodies shall rise” (26:19).
8. “In that day the LORD with his hard and great and strong sword will punish Leviathan” (27:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 24 describes universal judgment. It falls on everyone: priest and people, master and servant, buyer and seller. The cause is that humanity has broken “the everlasting covenant.” This is not just Israel’s sin but the sin of the whole human race, going back to Adam and Noah. The earth itself suffers under the guilt of its inhabitants.

Yet scattered through the judgment are glimpses of praise. From the ends of the earth, songs of glory to the Righteous One are heard. And then in chapter 25, an extended song of thanks. God has been a stronghold to the poor and needy, a shelter from the storm, a shade from the heat. He has done wonderful things, plans formed of old, faithful and sure.

The heart of the Apocalypse is Isaiah 25:6-9. On the mountain of the LORD, a feast is prepared for all peoples. This is not for Israel alone. It is the banquet of the kingdom. And the shroud that covers all peoples will be destroyed. “He will swallow up death forever.” God himself will wipe away tears from all faces. The disgrace of his people will be removed. And the people will say, “This is our God; we have waited for him, that he might save us.” The sight of death’s defeat is the central hope of the Old Testament.

Chapter 26 is a song for the day of salvation, and it contains the verse for this week: “You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you.” A mind fixed on God is a mind at rest. And verse 19, “Your dead shall live; their bodies shall rise,” is one of the clearest statements of resurrection in the Old Testament. Chapter 27 ends with the vineyard of Isaiah 5 restored: “Israel shall blossom and put forth shoots and fill the whole world with fruit.”

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Isaiah 25:8 in 1 Corinthians 15:54: “Death is swallowed up in victory.” Revelation 21:4 echoes: “He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more.” Jesus told of the great banquet (Luke 14:15-24) and the wedding feast (Matthew 22:1-14). Revelation 19:9 speaks of the marriage supper of the Lamb. Philippians 4:7 speaks of the peace of God that guards our hearts and minds in Christ Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Isaiah 26:3 and practice it when you feel anxious.

Think about someone who has died in Christ, and take comfort from the promise of resurrection.

Remember the banquet. Invite someone this week to a meal as a small picture of the feast.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for the wonderful things he has done.
- Thank him that he will swallow up death forever and wipe away tears.
- Tell him what tears you are bringing him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 395 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 28:1-30:33

Woes to Ephraim and Judah; “in quietness and trust”

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 28:1-30:33. These chapters are a series of woes aimed at the leaders of Israel and Judah. They are pointed and sometimes sarcastic. Look for the contrast between trusting in political schemes and “in quietness and trust.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

As the Assyrian threat grows, the leaders in Jerusalem begin to look to Egypt for a military alliance. Isaiah condemns the plan as a covenant with death. The woes of these chapters describe drunken priests, hypocritical worship, secret plans made without God, and people who tell the prophets to stop giving them hard truths. At the center is a beautiful word about the cornerstone that God lays in Zion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Woe to the proud crown of the drunkards of Ephraim” (28:1).
2. “Precept upon precept, precept upon precept, line upon line, line upon line, here a little, there a little” (28:10).
3. “You have said, We have made a covenant with death, and with Sheol we have an agreement” (28:15).
4. “Behold, I am the one who has laid as a foundation in Zion, a stone, a tested stone, a precious cornerstone, of a sure foundation: Whoever believes will not be in haste” (28:16).
5. “This people draw near with their mouth and honor me with their lips, while their hearts are far from me” (29:13).

6. “Woe to those who hide deep from the LORD their counsel” (29:15).
7. “In returning and rest you shall be saved; in quietness and in trust shall be your strength. But you were unwilling” (30:15).
8. “Therefore the LORD waits to be gracious to you, and therefore he exalts himself to show mercy to you” (30:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 28 begins with the drunken leaders of the northern kingdom, whose fall is near. Then it turns to Jerusalem’s priests and prophets, who also stagger in drink. They mock Isaiah’s simple teaching as baby talk. “Precept upon precept” is how they hear it. God replies that if they will not listen to simple words, they will hear foreign tongues, the language of the Assyrian invaders.

The leaders have made a “covenant with death.” They think they have cheated the grave by political deals. But God lays a different foundation: a tested stone, a precious cornerstone, “a sure foundation.” Whoever believes in him will not be in a panic. The standard of justice will be the plumb line. In the face of political panic, the faithful rest on the stone God has laid.

Chapter 29 criticizes hollow religion. The people honor God with their lips but their hearts are far from him, and their fear of God is a tradition learned by rote. They think that God cannot see their schemes. Isaiah says the potter is not the same as the clay. God sees everything, and yet his plan includes a coming day when “the deaf shall hear the words of a book, and out of their gloom the eyes of the blind shall see.”

Chapter 30 is the center of this section. The people are sending envoys to Egypt, trusting in Pharaoh’s protection, and refusing to listen to the prophets. They say, “Do not prophesy to us what is right; speak to us smooth things.” God’s offer is simple: “In returning and rest you shall be saved; in quietness and in trust shall be your strength. But you were unwilling.” The most tragic words in the passage. Yet verse 18 is full of grace: “The LORD waits to be gracious to you.” The God who is angry is also the God who waits, and who will answer the cry for help.

STEP 5

Connection

Peter quotes Isaiah 28:16 in 1 Peter 2:6 and calls Christ the cornerstone. Paul quotes it in Romans 9:33 and 10:11. Jesus quotes Isaiah 29:13 in Mark 7:6-7. Paul quotes Isaiah 29:14 in 1 Corinthians 1:19. Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of a Sabbath rest for the people of God. Psalm 46:10 says, “Be still, and know that I am God.” Matthew 11:28 offers rest to the weary.

STEP 6

Application

Practice “quietness and trust” for ten minutes today. Turn off every distraction and simply rest in God.

Ask yourself where you have made a “covenant with death,” a plan to avoid consequences or guarantee security without God.

Receive the truth that the LORD waits to be gracious to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the cornerstone he laid.

Confess where you honor him with lips but not heart.

Ask for quietness and trust.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

“You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you.”

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 396 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 31:1-35:10

Woe to those who go to Egypt; the highway of holiness

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 31:1-35:10. The woes continue against reliance on Egypt, but then chapters 32 to 35 move toward a glorious future. Read chapter 35 slowly, as a picture of the transformed world.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The crisis with Assyria is at its height. Hezekiah's advisors continue to look to Egypt for horses and chariots. Isaiah warns them against it, and then describes a righteous king, a poured-out Spirit, a coming judgment on Edom, and the joyful return of the redeemed along "the highway of holiness." Chapters 34 and 35 close the first half of Isaiah with a stark contrast between judgment and joy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Woe to those who go down to Egypt for help and rely on horses, who trust in chariots because they are many... but do not look to the Holy One of Israel" (31:1).
2. "The Egyptians are man, and not God, and their horses are flesh, and not spirit" (31:3).
3. "Behold, a king will reign in righteousness, and princes will rule in justice" (32:1).
4. "Until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high, and the wilderness becomes a fruitful field" (32:15).
5. "The effect of righteousness will be peace, and the result of righteousness, quietness and trust forever" (32:17).
6. "O LORD, be gracious to us; we wait for you" (33:2).

7. “For the LORD is our judge; the LORD is our lawgiver; the LORD is our king; he will save us” (33:22).

8. “And a highway shall be there, and it shall be called the Way of Holiness” (35:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The main sin of chapter 31 is stated plainly: trusting in horses and chariots rather than in the Holy One of Israel. Isaiah’s contrast is memorable: “The Egyptians are man, and not God, and their horses are flesh, and not spirit.” Whatever human power we trust in is limited by its own nature. The LORD of hosts will fight for Jerusalem like a lion over its prey or like birds hovering. He will protect and deliver.

Chapter 32 opens with a promise of a righteous king and a time when people will see clearly. It also speaks to the complacent women of the city, who will be shaken from their ease. But then, “until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high.” This is a promise of the Spirit’s coming and of a transformation of the land. The result is justice, righteousness, peace, and security. These flow from God’s Spirit.

Chapter 33 contains a prayer, “O LORD, be gracious to us; we wait for you,” and then the stunning reversal of the Assyrian threat. The enemy who dealt treacherously will be dealt with. Then the prophet asks who can live with the consuming fire, and answers: he who walks righteously and speaks uprightly. And the chapter ends with a great statement: “The LORD is our judge; the LORD is our lawgiver; the LORD is our king; he will save us.”

Chapter 34 is the dark side, a judgment on the nations, symbolized by Edom. And chapter 35 is the bright side. It is a poem of transformation. The desert blossoms. The weak hands are strengthened. The eyes of the blind are opened, the ears of the deaf unstopped, the lame leap like a deer, and the mute sing. A highway is built, the Way of Holiness. The unclean shall not pass over it, but the redeemed shall walk there. “The ransomed of the LORD shall return and come to Zion with singing; everlasting joy shall be upon their heads.” It is the vision of salvation as a return home.

STEP 5

Connection

When John the Baptist’s disciples asked Jesus if he was the one, Jesus answered by pointing to the signs of Isaiah 35: the blind see, the lame walk, the deaf hear (Matthew 11:2-5). Acts 2:17 quotes Joel on the pouring out of the Spirit, and Acts 2 shows its fulfillment. Jesus said, “I am the way” (John 14:6). Hebrews 12:12 echoes Isaiah 35:3. Revelation 21:4 says sorrow and sighing will flee away.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one “horse and chariot” you tend to trust, whether money, connections, or skills. Place it under God’s care.

Pray for the Spirit to be “poured out from on high” on your church and community.

Strengthen a weak hand this week by encouraging someone who is struggling.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you trust horses and chariots.
- Ask God to pour out his Spirit on his people.
- Thank him that he makes a highway of holiness for his redeemed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

“You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you.”

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 397 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 36:1-37:38

The Assyrian crisis; Hezekiah's prayer; Sennacherib falls

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 36:1-37:38. This is the same story you read in 2 Kings 18-19, now from Isaiah's side. Notice what is added: the sharpness of the Assyrian propaganda, the detail of Hezekiah's prayer, and the poem that Isaiah speaks against Sennacherib.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah 36-39 is a historical interlude that connects the two halves of the book. It repeats and expands the account in 2 Kings, with an important addition in Isaiah 38. In 701 BC, Sennacherib besieged Jerusalem after capturing the other cities of Judah. He sent his field commander to demoralize the city. This is the pivotal event of the first half of Isaiah: will the nation trust in God or in the powers of the world?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What is this trust of yours?" (36:4).
2. "Do not let Hezekiah deceive you, for he will not be able to deliver you" (36:14).
3. "Who among all the gods of these lands have delivered their lands out of my hand, that the LORD should deliver Jerusalem out of my hand?" (36:20).
4. "This day is a day of distress, of rebuke, and of disgrace" (37:3).
5. "O LORD of hosts, enthroned above the cherubim, you are the God, you alone, of all the kingdoms of the earth" (37:16).
6. "Incline your ear, O LORD, and hear; open your eyes, O LORD, and see" (37:17).
7. "Whom have you mocked and reviled? Against whom have you raised your voice?" (37:23).

8 “And the angel of the LORD went out and struck down 185,000 in the camp of the Assyrians” (37:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The field commander speaks like a skilled propagandist. He begins by undermining confidence in Egypt, then in Hezekiah, then in the LORD. He says that Hezekiah removed the altars of the LORD, which he distorts as an insult to God, though it was a reform. He claims that the LORD told him to attack Judah. And his final argument is the most dangerous: no god of any nation has saved it from Assyria, so why would the LORD? It places the LORD on the same level as the idols of the nations. It is a claim that God is no different from other gods, and it has to be answered.

Hezekiah’s response is quiet. The army is ordered not to answer. The king goes to the house of the LORD and sends for the prophet. Isaiah gives the first word: “Do not be afraid.” Then Sennacherib sends a second letter, and Hezekiah does the thing for which he is remembered. He spreads it out before the LORD. His prayer is a model. It begins with who God is: enthroned above the cherubim, the only God of all the kingdoms, the maker of heaven and earth. It describes the threat honestly. It makes a request: save us. And it states the purpose: “that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that you alone are the LORD.”

God’s answer through Isaiah is a poem of mockery against the proud king. “Whom have you mocked and reviled?” It was against the Holy One of Israel. The king thinks he has conquered by his own power, but God says, “Have you not heard that I determined it long ago?” Assyria was an instrument, and its pride is its downfall. God promises to put his hook in Sennacherib’s nose and turn him back the way he came.

That night the angel of the LORD strikes down 185,000 in the camp. In the morning, the army is dead. Sennacherib returns to Nineveh, and years later he is killed by his own sons while worshiping his god. The god he trusted could not protect him.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his disciples to pray in his name and promised that the Father would give what they asked (John 16:23-24). Hebrews 4:16 invites us to the throne of grace. 2 Corinthians 10:4-5 says our weapons are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds. Psalm 46 and Psalm 48, coming up, celebrate this deliverance. Revelation 12:11 says the saints conquer by the blood of the Lamb and the word of their testimony.

STEP 6

Application

Use Hezekiah's prayer as a pattern: begin with who God is, bring the problem honestly, make your request, and state your purpose.

When voices tell you that no one can help you, remember the 185,000.

Write down a problem and, as Hezekiah did, spread it before the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Spread before God what troubles you, as Hezekiah did.

Ask him to incline his ear and open his eyes.

Praise him as the God, you alone.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 398 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 38:1-39:8

Hezekiah's illness and recovery; the Babylonian envoys

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 38:1-39:8. Hezekiah becomes ill, prays, and is given fifteen more years. Then he makes a mistake with the Babylonian envoys. Read the prayer of thanks in 38:9-20, and notice the sober ending.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last section of the historical interlude. In about 703 BC, Hezekiah became deathly ill. The prophet told him to set his house in order, because he would die. The king turned his face to the wall and prayed. God heard and added fifteen years to his life. Then envoys arrived from Merodach-baladan of Babylon, ostensibly to congratulate him. The story serves as a hinge: the Assyrian threat is over, but the Babylonian one is coming.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Set your house in order, for you shall die, you shall not recover" (38:1).
2. "Then Hezekiah turned his face to the wall and prayed to the LORD" (38:2).
3. "Remember how I have walked before you in faithfulness and with a whole heart" (38:3).
4. "I have heard your prayer; I have seen your tears. Behold, I will add fifteen years to your life" (38:5).
5. "Behold, it was for my welfare that I had great bitterness; but in love you have delivered my life from the pit of destruction, for you have cast all my sins behind your back" (38:17).
6. "For Sheol does not thank you; death does not praise you" (38:18).

7. “And Hezekiah was pleased, and showed them his treasure house” (39:2).
8. “Days are coming, when all that is in your house… shall be carried to Babylon. Nothing shall be left” (39:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The illness comes at the same time as the Assyrian threat, perhaps in the same year. For Hezekiah, the news that he would die meant more than personal loss. He had no son, and the Davidic line seemed at risk. He weeps bitterly and prays. His prayer is honest: remember how I have walked before you. It is not self-righteous but an appeal to the covenant relationship. And God answers. “I have heard your prayer; I have seen your tears.” He gives a sign: the shadow on the stairway goes backward ten steps.

Hezekiah’s psalm records his experience. He describes his life cut off like a weaver rolling up a cloth. He moans like a dove. And then comes the turning point in verse 17: “In love you have delivered my life from the pit of destruction, for you have cast all my sins behind your back.” It is one of the most beautiful phrases in the Bible about forgiveness. What was behind God’s back is out of his sight. And the king concludes that the living thank God: “The fathers make known to the children your faithfulness.” The purpose of his extra years is to praise and to pass faith on.

Then chapter 39 delivers the sad aftermath. When the envoys of Babylon come, Hezekiah is flattered and shows them everything in his house and in all his realm. It may have been vanity, or a political move to find allies against Assyria. Either way, he looked to a human power instead of to God. Isaiah’s rebuke is solemn: everything will go to Babylon, and some of your own sons will be eunuchs in the palace of the king of Babylon.

Hezekiah’s reply is the most unsettling part: “The word of the LORD that you have spoken is good. For there will be peace and security in my days.” He accepts the word but seems concerned only with his own lifetime. The man who cried out for his life does not cry out for his descendants. Even great believers can be weak in the face of success.

STEP 5

Connection

Micah 7:19 says God will cast all our sins into the depths of the sea, and Colossians 2:13-14 says Christ canceled the record of debt. Psalm 103:12 says he removes our transgressions as far as the east is from the west. James 5:14-16 teaches us to pray for the sick. 2 Timothy 4:7 shows Paul finishing the race well, a contrast with Hezekiah’s mixed ending. Jesus warns in Luke 12:15-21 about the rich man who thinks only of his own ease.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God for any season of extra time, health, or opportunity, and ask what he wants you to do with it.

Pray for the generation after you, as Hezekiah's psalm says: make known God's faithfulness to the children.

Ask whether you have shown your treasures to the world in pride. Return the glory to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for hearing your prayer and seeing your tears.

Thank him for casting your sins behind his back.

Ask him to keep you from pride in the good he gives.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 399 · WEEK 57

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 26:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

REST

Meditation

This promise comes in the middle of Isaiah's apocalypse, a section about the shaking of the whole earth. It is a song of confidence for the day of salvation, sung in a time of upheaval. Peace is promised, and it is promised in the midst of unrest.

"You keep him in perfect peace." In Hebrew, the words are "peace, peace," shalom shalom. The double word indicates fullness, a peace that is complete. It is not the absence of trouble but wholeness: well-being in body, soul, and relationships. And the one who gives it is God. He keeps, or guards, the person. The word is used of a sentry on watch.

"Whose mind is stayed on you." The word "stayed" means supported, leaning, resting on something. The mind that is steadied by God is a mind that is propped up. It is a picture of leaning on God, as one leans on a strong staff. The mind in view is not only intellect but the whole inner life, our thoughts, imaginings, and desires. When the center of our attention is God, the heart is stable.

“Because he trusts in you.” The ground of the peace is trust. The man in this verse is not free of problems. He is anchored. Isaiah’s contrast is clear throughout this week’s reading: the people of Judah were anxious because they trusted in Egypt, in treaties, and in horses. The peace came to those who trusted in the LORD, like Hezekiah on the day he spread the letter before him.

Say this verse in times of worry and ask what you are leaning on. In Christ, the Prince of Peace has made peace for us through his blood. He now says, “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you.”

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the middle chapters of Isaiah’s first half. You prayed Psalm 83 against a coalition of enemy nations and saw that the real aim is that they would know the LORD is the Most High. You read the Isaiah Apocalypse, with its picture of a feast on God’s mountain, the swallowing up of death, and the promise of resurrection. You read the woes against trusting in Egypt, and the beautiful invitation to “return and rest.” You saw the cornerstone laid in Zion and heard of the Way of Holiness. Then you followed the Assyrian crisis through Isaiah’s eyes: Hezekiah spreading the letter before the LORD, the angel striking the camp, and the king’s illness, his healing, and his misstep with Babylon. The week taught that peace belongs to the mind that is stayed on God, and that those who trust in worldly power will be disappointed.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah calls us to “quietness and trust” rather than frantic human schemes. Where do you need to stop striving and rest in God?

Isaiah 25:8 promises that God will swallow up death forever and wipe away tears. How does this promise speak to your own grief or fear?

Hezekiah faithfully prayed in a crisis but was careless in success. In what area of your life is prosperity a bigger test than trouble?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you in perfect peace with your mind stayed on him.

Thank Christ for swallowing up death in victory.

Rest in quietness and trust.

DAY 400 · WEEK 58

Psalm 46

God is our refuge, Hezekiah's psalm

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 46. You have read it before, but read it now as the song Jerusalem sang after the night the Assyrian army fell. Notice the river, the refrain, and the command in verse 10.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 46 is a song of the sons of Korah. Many readers connect it to the deliverance of Jerusalem from Sennacherib, which you have just read. A city with no great river, Jerusalem is given a river in this psalm, a stream whose waters make glad the city of God. Martin Luther's hymn "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God" was inspired by it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble" (v. 1).
2. "Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way, though the mountains be moved into the heart of the sea" (v. 2).
3. "There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God, the holy habitation of the Most High" (v. 4).
4. "God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns" (v. 5).
5. "The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts" (v. 6).
6. "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress" (v. 7).
7. "He makes wars cease to the end of the earth; he breaks the bow and shatters the spear" (v. 9).

8 “Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm has three stanzas, each ending with a refrain, though the refrain is missing from the first stanza in our texts. The first describes the cosmos in chaos: earth giving way, mountains slipping into the sea, waters roaring. These are pictures of the greatest disaster the ancient mind could imagine. And the response is: “We will not fear.” The reason is not that the danger is small, but that God is a refuge, a very present help.

The second stanza turns to the city. In contrast to the roaring sea is a quiet river. The sea in ancient thought was a symbol of chaos, but Jerusalem has a stream that makes glad the city of God. This is a picture of God’s presence that gives life. And “God will help her when morning dawns.” Recall the 185,000 who lay dead in the morning. The help came at daybreak. The nations rage, but a single word from him melts the earth. The refrain says: “The LORD of hosts is with us.” It is the name Immanuel in the language of the psalms.

The third stanza invites us to look: “Come, behold the works of the LORD.” He makes wars cease, breaks the bow, shatters the spear, burns the chariots. What does that look like? It looks like an empty Assyrian camp.

Then the voice of God himself: “Be still, and know that I am God.” This is not a gentle suggestion to relax, though it may include that. The Hebrew word means “cease striving.” It is addressed to the nations as well as to Israel. Stop fighting, and know who is God. In Hezekiah’s case, the king was told to be quiet and the army to be silent. God did the fighting. The call to stillness is a call to trust, to stop relying on our own efforts and to rest in the one who is exalted among the nations.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calmed the sea with a word (Mark 4:39), showing that he is the one who rules the chaotic waters. Romans 8:31 asks, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” Revelation 22:1 describes a river of the water of life flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb, the true fulfillment of the river of the city of God. Hebrews 12:28 says we receive a kingdom that cannot be shaken. Matthew 28:20 echoes: “I am with you always.”

STEP 6

Application

Say the refrain, “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress,” every time you feel afraid today.

Practice verse 10. Sit in stillness for five minutes and simply know that he is God.

Think of a “morning” when God helped you after a long night. Thank him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what in your life feels like the earth giving way.
- Thank him that he is a very present help.
- Be still before him for a moment.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

“But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.”

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 401 · WEEK 58

Psalm 48

Walk about Zion, the city of God is secure

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 48. It is a song celebrating Jerusalem, "the city of our God." Imagine walking around the walls and counting the towers, as the psalm invites you to do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 48 is a song of the sons of Korah. It follows Psalm 46 in this unit and in its original collection. The kings of the earth gathered against Zion, saw it, and fled in panic. It is the song of a city that has been delivered. You read it in Unit 9 as a song about the city of David. Today read it as the song of a city that has seen the Assyrian army vanish.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Great is the LORD and greatly to be praised in the city of our God! His holy mountain, beautiful in elevation, is the joy of all the earth" (vv. 1-2).
2. "Within her citadels God has made himself known as a fortress" (v. 3).
3. "For behold, the kings assembled; they came on together" (v. 4).
4. "As soon as they saw it, they were astounded; they were in panic; they took to flight" (v. 5).
5. "As we have heard, so have we seen in the city of the LORD of hosts" (v. 8).
6. "We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple" (v. 9).
7. "Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers, consider well her ramparts, go through her citadels" (vv. 12-13).
8. "That you may tell the next generation that this is God, our God forever and ever. He will guide us forever" (vv. 13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with praise to the LORD and then to his city. The beauty of Zion is not the city for its own sake, but because of the God who lives there. The mountain is "the joy of all the earth," and "the city of the great King." In the ancient world, a city was only as good as its god. The psalmist insists that Jerusalem's strength comes from its God.

The account of the enemies in verses 4 to 7 is brief and almost comic. The kings gathered, they came together, they saw, they were astounded, they fled. It is like a wave dissolving. Like "ships of Tarshish shattered by an east wind." This is the same truth as Psalm 46 and Psalm 76: God defends his city.

Verse 9 is the center of the psalm. After the military story, the psalmist turns to the temple. "We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple." The greatest thing about the deliverance is not the defeat of enemies but what it reveals about God's covenant love. The people reflect on it in worship.

Then comes a strange invitation: "Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers." Walk the walls. Count what is still there. After a great threat, check that everything is intact. And the purpose: "that you may tell the next generation that this is God." This is an educational walk. The visible city teaches children about God's faithfulness. The final verse is a confession: "This is God, our God forever and ever. He will guide us forever." The Hebrew can even be read "guide us beyond death."

The psalm reminds us to remember what God has done and to pass it on.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 5:35 calls Jerusalem "the city of the great King." Hebrews 12:22 says that believers have come "to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem." Revelation 21:2 describes the new Jerusalem coming down from heaven, and verse 23 says it has no need of sun or moon, for the glory of God is its light. Matthew 16:18 says that the gates of hell will not prevail against the church. Deuteronomy 6:7 commands us to tell the next generation.

STEP 6

Application

Take a "walk about Zion." List ten things God has done for your church or family, and number them like towers.

Tell a child, a new believer, or a friend one story of God's faithfulness this week.

Think on God's steadfast love, as the psalm says, during a time of worship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for the security of his city.
- Tell him what you have thought on of his steadfast love.
- Ask him to guide you forever.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 402 · WEEK 58

Isaiah 40:1-42:25

"Comfort my people"; the Servant introduced

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 40:1-42:25. The second half of Isaiah begins here. The mood shifts from judgment to comfort. Read chapter 40 slowly, and listen for the voice crying in the wilderness.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah 40 opens the second half of the book. Chapters 40 to 55 speak to a people who, in the prophet's vision, are in exile in Babylon, as Isaiah 39 foretold. The message is "Comfort, comfort my people." God is going to bring them back. These chapters present the incomparable God, his Servant, and his plan to redeem. They are some of the most beautiful and doctrinally rich in the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Comfort, comfort my people, says your God. Speak tenderly to Jerusalem" (40:1-2).
2. "A voice cries: In the wilderness prepare the way of the LORD" (40:3).
3. "The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God will stand forever" (40:8).
4. "Behold your God! ... He will tend his flock like a shepherd; he will gather the lambs in his arms" (40:9, 11).
5. "To whom then will you compare me, that I should be like him? says the Holy One" (40:25).
6. "They who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles" (40:31).

7. “Behold my servant, whom I uphold, my chosen, in whom my soul delights; I have put my Spirit upon him; he will bring forth justice to the nations” (42:1).

8. “A bruised reed he will not break, and a faintly burning wick he will not quench” (42:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Isaiah 40 begins with a double command: “Comfort, comfort my people.” After the long section of judgment, God speaks tenderly. The warfare is ended, the iniquity pardoned. The people have received double for their sins, which means that their punishment is complete. A voice cries out for a highway to be built for the LORD in the wilderness. This is the announcement of God’s own return to his people.

The chapter next deals with the reasons for trust. First, God’s word stands forever, though human strength is like grass. Second, God is a shepherd who carries the lambs in his arms and gently leads those that are with young. Third, God is incomparable. He measured the waters in the hollow of his hand. The nations are like a drop from a bucket. The idols are made by craftsmen who nail them in place so they do not fall. Those who sit in exile feel forgotten, but God never grows weary. He gives power to the faint and strengthens the weak. Those who wait for him renew their strength.

Chapter 41 continues with God’s courtroom challenge to the idols and the nations. “Fear not, for I am with you; be not dismayed, for I am your God.” To Israel, called “worm Jacob,” he says that he is their redeemer, the Holy One of Israel.

Then in chapter 42 appears the first of the Servant Songs. “Behold my servant.” He is chosen, upheld, and endowed with God’s Spirit. His mission is to bring justice to the nations, not with a loud voice but with gentleness. “A bruised reed he will not break.” The Servant does not crush the weak. He will not grow faint or be discouraged until he has established justice in the earth. And the coastlands wait for his law.

The Servant is a mystery in Isaiah, and the question of who he is will keep returning. In this song, he is presented as the one who will bring God’s justice, with compassion for the weak.

STEP 5

Connection

All four Gospels apply Isaiah 40:3 to John the Baptist (Matthew 3:3; Mark 1:2-3; Luke 3:4-6; John 1:23). Matthew 12:15-21 quotes Isaiah 42:1-4 and applies it to Jesus. At his baptism, the Father’s voice echoed this, “my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased” (Matthew 3:17). 1 Peter 1:24-25 quotes Isaiah 40:6-8. John 10:11 shows Jesus as the good shepherd. Matthew 11:28-30 reveals his gentleness.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Isaiah 40:31, and apply it to an area where you are weary.

Think of someone who feels like a bruised reed. Be gentle with them this week.

Spend time meditating on the greatness of God in Isaiah 40:12-26, and let it shrink your problems.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to comfort his people, including you.
- Ask him to prepare the way in your heart.
- Thank him for the shepherd who carries the lambs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 403 · WEEK 58

Isaiah 43:1-45:25

You are mine; the only God; Cyrus named

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 43:1-45:25. God declares that he is the only God, he promises to redeem Israel, and he names Cyrus, a pagan king, as his instrument more than a century before he was born. Read with attention to the repeated “I am the LORD.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The exiles in Babylon thought that their God had been defeated by the gods of Babylon. Isaiah answers that God is not only sovereign but alone. The chapters here contain some of the strongest statements of monotheism in the Bible. They also contain the astonishing prophecy that Cyrus of Persia, who conquered Babylon in 539 BC, would be God’s shepherd to free his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Fear not, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by name, you are mine” (43:1).
2. “When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and through the rivers, they shall not overwhelm you” (43:2).
3. “I, I am the LORD, and besides me there is no savior” (43:11).
4. “Behold, I am doing a new thing; now it springs forth, do you not perceive it?” (43:19).
5. “I, I am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake, and I will not remember your sins” (43:25).
6. “Before me no god was formed, nor shall there be any after me” (43:10).
7. “Who says of Cyrus, He is my shepherd, and he shall fulfill all my purpose” (44:28).

8 “Turn to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth! For I am God, and there is no other” (45:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 43 opens with “But now.” After the discipline of exile, God speaks. “Fear not, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by name, you are mine.” Notice the order: redemption first, then the claim. Israel is his because he bought them. Then the promises: through the waters, the rivers, the fire. These echo the sea and the Jordan. He will gather them from the ends of the earth.

God then argues against the idols. The nations are summoned to a court. Who among them declared the things that would happen? Israel is God’s witness: “You are my witnesses… and my servant whom I have chosen.” There is only one God and one Savior. The strongest part comes next. Though Israel has not called on him, wearied him with sins, and burdened him with iniquities, “I, I am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake, and I will not remember your sins.” Forgiveness comes from God’s own initiative, not from Israel’s merit.

Chapter 44 contains a famous satire on idolatry. A man cuts down a tree, burns half for warming himself and cooking, and carves the rest into a god and bows down to it. “Deliver me, for you are my god!” Isaiah exposes the foolishness: it is a lie in his right hand. In contrast, the LORD says, “I formed you; you are my servant; O Israel, I will not forget you.”

At the end of chapter 44 and in chapter 45, Cyrus is named. God calls him “my shepherd” and “his anointed.” A pagan king who does not know the LORD is used for God’s purposes. This shows that God is sovereign over history, even over those who do not acknowledge him. God’s purpose is that people “may know, from the rising of the sun and from the west, that there is none besides me.”

The invitation at the end of chapter 45 is a gospel call: “Turn to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth!” One day every knee will bow.

STEP 5

Connection

Philippians 2:10-11 quotes Isaiah 45:23: every knee will bow and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord. Revelation 2:17 and John 10:3 echo God’s calling us by name. Acts 4:12 says there is salvation in no one else. Hebrews 8:12 says that God will remember our sins no more. 2 Corinthians 5:17 speaks of the new creation: “the old has passed away; behold, the new has come.” Romans 9:20-21 draws on the potter and clay imagery of Isaiah 45:9.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud Isaiah 43:1 as a statement about you: “I have called you by name, you are mine.”

Notice a “new thing” that God may be doing in your life. Ask for eyes to see it.

Reflect on “Cyrus.” How has God used people who do not know him to serve you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are called by name and are his.

Thank him that he is with you in the waters.

Thank him for blotting out your transgressions.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

“But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.”

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 404 · WEEK 58

Psalm 86

I am poor and needy; you are good and forgiving

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 86. It is a prayer of David for help, based entirely on God's goodness, not on David's merit. Notice how many times David calls himself God's servant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 86 is the only psalm in Book 3 attributed to David. It is a personal prayer in the middle of a series of national psalms of Asaph and the sons of Korah. The psalmist is surrounded by insolent men, but the focus is on God's character. It takes up the language of Exodus 34:6, which you saw in Jonah: "merciful and gracious, slow to anger." The psalm balances Isaiah's mighty God with the personal God who hears one man.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Incline your ear, O LORD, and answer me, for I am poor and needy" (v. 1).
2. "Preserve my life, for I am godly; save your servant, who trusts in you" (v. 2).
3. "Gladden the soul of your servant, for to you, O Lord, do I lift up my soul" (v. 4).
4. "For you, O Lord, are good and forgiving, abounding in steadfast love to all who call on you" (v. 5).
5. "There is none like you among the gods, O Lord, nor are there any works like yours" (v. 8).
6. "All the nations you have made shall come and worship before you, O Lord" (v. 9).
7. "Teach me your way, O LORD, that I may walk in your truth; unite my heart to fear your name" (v. 11).

8 “But you, O Lord, are a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness” (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with the simplest sort of prayer: “I am poor and needy.” David does not mean he lacks money. He means he has nothing that gives him a claim on God. Every request that follows rests on God’s character. “Preserve my life, for I am godly” does not boast of perfection but states his covenant loyalty. “You are good and forgiving, abounding in steadfast love to all who call on you.” That is the heart of the psalm. He asks because God is generous.

David repeatedly calls himself “your servant,” three times in the psalm. The word shows his posture: he belongs to God and depends on him. Being a servant means that he can ask for the master’s protection. And his daily prayer is persistent. “I cry to you all the day.”

Verses 8 to 10 widen the view: no one is like the LORD. All nations will come and worship. This echoes Isaiah 45:22-23 and the mission to the nations. Even a personal prayer is set in a universal frame.

The central request is in verse 11: “Teach me your way, O LORD, that I may walk in your truth; unite my heart to fear your name.” David asks for a divided heart to be united. Anyone who has tried to follow God knows how scattered the heart can be, pulled in many directions. He prays that God would gather it into a single loyalty. It is a prayer that is worth praying every day.

Then he thanks God for deliverance from Sheol. The proud have risen against him. He asks for a sign of God’s goodness, “that those who hate me may see and be put to shame, because you, LORD, have helped me and comforted me.” The psalm moves from need to confidence, and its core is God’s self-description from Exodus 34, spoken back to him in prayer.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Psalm 86 in the thought that all nations will worship (Romans 15:9-11, along with Psalm 18 and others). Revelation 15:4 says, “All nations will come and worship you.” Ephesians 2:4-5 speaks of God, rich in mercy. James 4:8 says, “Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you… purify your hearts, you double-minded.” Matthew 6:22 and Psalm 119:113 address wholeheartedness. 2 Corinthians 1:3-4 calls him the Father of mercies and God of all comfort.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Psalm 86:11 each morning this week: “Unite my heart to fear your name.”

Begin a prayer by admitting that you are “poor and needy,” with nothing to bring but your need.

Speak God’s own words about himself (Exodus 34:6) back to him in a prayer of trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that you are poor and needy.
- Thank him that he is good and forgiving.
- Ask him to teach you his way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

“But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.”

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 405 · WEEK 58

Psalm 89:1-37

I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 89:1-37. The first half of the psalm celebrates God's covenant with David. It is a magnificent statement of confidence. Keep in mind that the second half of the psalm (verses 38-52), which comes later in the plan, brings a painful question.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 89 is a Maskil of Ethan the Ezrahite and the last psalm of Book 3. It was probably written after the Babylonian exile began, when the Davidic king had been taken captive. Yet the first thirty-seven verses are full of praise for the covenant God made with David in 2 Samuel 7. It is placed here in Unit 12 as a bridge between Isaiah's promises of a coming king and the later crisis. Verses 38 to 52 appear in Unit 13.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever; with my mouth I will make known your faithfulness to all generations" (v. 1).
2. "For I said, Steadfast love will be built up forever; in the heavens you will establish your faithfulness" (v. 2).
3. "You have said, I have made a covenant with my chosen one; I have sworn to David my servant" (v. 3).
4. "Who in the skies can be compared to the LORD? Who among the heavenly beings is like the LORD?" (v. 6).
5. "Blessed are the people who know the festal shout, who walk, O LORD, in the light of your face" (v. 15).

6. “I have found David, my servant; with my holy oil I have anointed him” (v. 20).
7. “He shall cry to me, You are my Father, my God, and the Rock of my salvation” (v. 26).
8. “I will not violate my covenant or alter the word that went forth from my lips” (v. 34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the word “steadfast love” and “faithfulness,” repeated throughout. These two words are used seven times in the first part of the psalm. The psalmist makes a vow: he will sing of them forever. His confidence rests on what God has said and sworn. God’s love is not a feeling that fluctuates but a covenant that stands.

The first section praises God as the creator and ruler. The heavens praise his wonders. No one is like him. He rules the raging sea, stills its waves, and crushed Rahab, the sea monster. North and south, Tabor and Hermon, all belong to him. And such a God is not distant. Blessed are those who walk in the light of his face.

The second part, verses 19 to 37, recalls the covenant with David in detail. God chose David from among the people, anointed him, strengthened him. He promised that David would call him Father, and that God would make him the firstborn, “the highest of the kings of the earth.” His line would endure as long as the heavens. Even if his sons sin, God says, “I will punish their transgression with the rod,” but “I will not remove from him my steadfast love.” Then the oath: “Once for all I have sworn by my holiness; I will not lie to David.”

Why does this matter in Unit 12? Because Isaiah’s promises of a child, a shoot of Jesse, and a servant all depend on the covenant with David. The psalm is the legal basis for hope. When Judah’s kingdom is threatened, this is what the faithful return to: God has sworn, and he will not lie.

The psalm’s second half asks, “But now you have cast off and rejected.” The painful tension between promise and experience is what the Old Testament waits for Christ to resolve.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:32-33 says that the angel told Mary her son would be given the throne of his father David. Acts 13:22-23 says God raised up from David’s offspring a Savior, Jesus. Hebrews 1:5 uses 2 Samuel 7 to say “I will be to him a father.” Colossians 1:18 calls Jesus “the firstborn of all creation” and “the firstborn from the dead.” Revelation 1:5 calls him “the ruler of kings on earth.” Romans 15:8 says Christ confirmed the promises given to the patriarchs.

STEP 6

Application

Choose to sing, or read aloud, Psalm 89:1 as a vow to make known God's faithfulness.

Think about one promise of God that you are holding on to. Write down the verse and what it says.

Thank God that his covenant is not broken by our failure, because Christ has fulfilled it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing of God's steadfast love in your own words.

Thank him for his sworn promise to David.

Ask him to make known his faithfulness to those who come after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 406 · WEEK 58

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 40:31 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

REST

Meditation

This verse comes at the end of a long argument. The exiles in Babylon had said, "My way is hidden from the LORD." Isaiah answers with a series of reasons to hope: the LORD is the Creator, never weary, whose understanding no one can fathom. And then comes the promise.

"But they who wait for the LORD." The Hebrew word for wait does not mean to sit idly. It means to hope, to look expectantly, as a person watches for the dawn. It has the sense of being bound to someone, twisted together like a rope. To wait for the LORD is to tie your hope to him. This is not passive. It is a posture of active trust.

"Shall renew their strength." The word "renew" means exchange. We trade our strength for his. The previous verses say that even the young grow faint and weary, and young men fall exhausted. Human strength has limits. But those who wait on God exchange their exhaustion

for his inexhaustible power.

Then three pictures, in an unusual order. “They shall mount up with wings like eagles.” This is the most dramatic. “They shall run and not be weary.” This is steadier. “They shall walk and not faint.” This is the most ordinary, and perhaps the greatest miracle. Most of life is walking, not soaring. The promise is that God will sustain us in the daily grind as well as in the heights.

Say this verse in a time of fatigue. You may not feel like an eagle today. You may only be walking. The promise is that you will not faint, for you are leaning on the one who “does not faint or grow weary” (Isaiah 40:28).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you stood with Judah as Jerusalem celebrated its deliverance from Assyria, singing Psalms 46 and 48, with their refrain, “The LORD of hosts is with us,” and their command, “Be still, and know that I am God.” Then you crossed the great divide in the book of Isaiah. In chapters 40 to 42, God speaks comfort to exiles, prepares a highway in the wilderness, and introduces the Servant who will not break a bruised reed. In chapters 43 to 45, you heard the LORD claim his people by name, declare that there is no savior besides him, and name Cyrus as his shepherd. You prayed Psalm 86, a prayer of the poor and needy to a God who is good and forgiving, and Psalm 89, a song about the covenant God swore to David. The week taught that God comforts his people, that he is the only God, and that his covenant promises stand.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah 40 begins, “Comfort, comfort my people.” Where do you most need to hear God’s comfort right now?

The Servant of Isaiah 42 does not break a bruised reed. How does Jesus’ gentleness with the weak change how you approach him in your own weakness?

God says, “I have called you by name, you are mine.” What difference would it make today if you lived as someone who truly belongs to him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give power to the faint, and tell him where you are faint.

Thank him for the Servant who does not break a bruised reed.

Wait for him and ask him to renew your strength.

DAY 407 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 46:1-49:26

Babylon's gods fail; "I have called you by name"

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 100 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 46:1-49:26. Babylon's gods are carried off on wagons, Babylon herself falls, and the Servant speaks in the first person. Notice the contrast between a god who must be carried and a God who carries.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The prophet speaks to exiles who see the glittering idols of Babylon every day. Chapters 46 and 47 contrast the gods who are carried with the God who carries, and announce the fall of proud Babylon. In chapters 48 and 49, God exhorts a stubborn people, and the second Servant Song appears. Here the Servant speaks for himself, and we learn that his work is larger than Israel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bel bows down; Nebo stoops; their idols are on beasts and livestock; these things you carry are loaded as burdens on weary beasts" (46:1).
2. "Even to your old age I am he, and to gray hairs I will carry you. I have made, and I will bear; I will carry and will save" (46:4).
3. "I am God, and there is none like me, declaring the end from the beginning" (46:9-10).
4. "You said, I shall be mistress forever" (47:7).
5. "I am the LORD your God, who teaches you to profit, who leads you in the way you should go" (48:17).
6. "The LORD called me from the womb, from the body of my mother he named my name" (49:1).

7. “It is too light a thing that you should be my servant to raise up the tribes of Jacob… I will make you as a light for the nations, that my salvation may reach to the end of the earth” (49:6).

8. “Can a woman forget her nursing child… Even these may forget, yet I will not forget you. Behold, I have engraved you on the palms of my hands” (49:15-16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 46 gives a stark image. The great gods of Babylon, Bel and Nebo, are loaded onto animals and carted off into captivity. Idols are heavy burdens that have to be carried, and they cannot save. Over against them is the God who carries: “I have made, and I will bear; I will carry and will save.” The difference between the true God and the false is the difference between a weight and a carrier. One needs to be carried by us. The other carries us, from birth to gray hairs.

Chapter 47 is a taunt song against Babylon, depicted as a pampered queen who sits on a throne and is told to sit in the dust. She thought, “I am, and there is no one besides me,” a boast that belongs only to God. Her sorcerers and astrologers cannot save her. The pride that exalts itself to the place of God is brought low.

In chapter 48, God addresses the stubborn exiles who invoke his name but not in truth. He declares the future before it happens so that they cannot say their idols did it. And he laments: “Oh that you had paid attention to my commandments! Then your peace would have been like a river.” Yet he will bring them out: “Go out from Babylon, flee from Chaldea.”

Chapter 49 introduces the Servant speaking, “Listen to me, O coastlands.” He was called before birth, his mouth made like a sharp sword, hidden in the shadow of God’s hand. Strikingly, he says, “I have labored in vain.” Yet his work is given to God. The commission is expanded: it is too light a thing to restore Israel alone. He will be “a light for the nations.” The Servant’s mission is global.

The chapter ends with the loveliest assurance. Zion says, “The LORD has forsaken me.” God answers that a mother may forget her nursing child, but he will not forget. “I have engraved you on the palms of my hands.” The hands that were scarred are the hands that remember.

STEP 5

Connection

Simeon quoted Isaiah 49:6 when he held the infant Jesus and called him “a light for revelation to the Gentiles” (Luke 2:32). Paul and Barnabas applied it to their mission in Acts 13:47. In John 8:12, Jesus says, “I am the light of the world.” The scars on the hands of Jesus

(John 20:27) are the true fulfillment of “engraved on the palms of my hands.” Revelation 18 shows the fall of Babylon the great.

STEP 6

Application

Name something you are carrying that you were never meant to carry, and give it to the God who carries.

Read Isaiah 49:15-16 slowly, and let it reassure you if you feel forgotten.

Pray for the spread of the gospel to the ends of the earth, as the Servant’s mission calls.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he will carry you to your old age.

Thank him that you are engraved on the palms of his hands.

Tell him what idol you are tempted to carry yourself.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

“But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed.”

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 408 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 50:1-53:12

The Servant's obedience; the suffering servant

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 50:1-53:12. This is the heart of the book. The Servant is obedient, beaten, and then, in chapter 53, pierced for our transgressions. Read Isaiah 52:13-53:12 twice. Let the language slow you down.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters contain the third and fourth Servant Songs. Isaiah 50:4-9 describes the Servant's willing suffering. Isaiah 52:13 to 53:12 is the most famous passage in the Old Testament about the Messiah's suffering and death. It was written about 700 years before Jesus. Early Christians, including Philip with the Ethiopian official in Acts 8, took this chapter as the key to understanding the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I gave my back to those who strike, and my cheeks to those who pull out the beard; I hid not my face from disgrace and spitting" (50:6).
2. "But the Lord GOD helps me; therefore I have not been disgraced" (50:7).
3. "Awake, awake, put on your strength, O arm of the LORD" (51:9).
4. "How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace" (52:7).
5. "Behold, my servant shall act wisely; he shall be high and lifted up, and shall be exalted" (52:13).
6. "He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief" (53:3).

7. “Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted” (53:4).

8. “But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed” (53:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 50 gives the Servant’s own voice. He is a disciple who listens, with an ear opened by God, morning by morning. He does not turn back. He gives his back to those who strike, and his face to those who spit. Yet he has set his face like a flint. His trust is in the God who helps him, and so he is not put to shame. The perfect obedience the Servant gives is what Israel never offered.

Chapter 51 and the beginning of 52 contain a great call to awake. God’s arm is stirred as in the days of old, when he cut Rahab in pieces and dried up the sea. And the ransomed of the LORD will return with singing. “How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news.” The whole earth will see the salvation of our God.

Then comes the fourth song. It begins with a surprise. The Servant will be “high and lifted up,” language used of God in Isaiah 6. Yet his appearance was marred beyond human semblance. Kings will shut their mouths because of him. Then the confession of the people begins in 53:1. He grew up like a tender plant, with no form or majesty. He was despised, rejected, a man of sorrows. “We esteemed him stricken, smitten by God.” We thought he was being punished for his own sins. But verses 5 and 6 reveal the truth: “He was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities.” Everything he suffered was for us. “All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned every one to his own way; and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all.”

The Servant is silent like a lamb led to the slaughter. He was cut off from the land of the living, assigned a grave with the wicked and with a rich man in his death, though he had done no violence. Yet “it was the will of the LORD to crush him.” Out of his anguish he will see light and be satisfied. “By his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities.” He pours out his soul to death, is numbered with the transgressors, bears the sin of many, and makes intercession.

STEP 5

Connection

Philip began with Isaiah 53 and told the Ethiopian official the good news about Jesus (Acts 8:32-35). 1 Peter 2:22-25 draws on this chapter for the cross. Matthew 8:17 sees Jesus’ healing as fulfilling “he took our illnesses.” Mark 10:45 says the Son of Man came “to give his life as a

ransom for many." Luke 22:37 quotes "he was numbered with the transgressors." Romans 5:19 speaks of the many being made righteous through one man's obedience.

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 53:4-6 aloud and replace "our" with "my." Let it become personal.

Thank Jesus specifically for one thing he bore for you: your guilt, shame, sorrow, or sickness.

Share the good news of this chapter with someone this week, as Philip did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being despised and rejected for you.
- Tell him what it means that he was pierced for your transgressions.
- Ask him to make you trust his healing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 409 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 53:1-12; Romans 3:21-26; Hebrews 9:11-28

The Work of Christ, Atonement

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 53:1-12, then Romans 3:21-26, and then Hebrews 9:11-28. Today is a doctrinal pause, so you are reading three passages together: the prophet's picture of the suffering Servant, Paul's explanation of how God justifies sinners, and the author of Hebrews on the blood of Christ. Ask as you read: what exactly did Jesus accomplish on the cross, and how?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You read Isaiah 53 yesterday. Today you read it again, alongside two New Testament passages that interpret it. Paul explains that God's righteousness is shown in the cross and that sinners are justified by grace through faith. The author of Hebrews shows that Christ's sacrifice fulfills and surpasses the Old Testament sacrifices. Together they give us the doctrine of the atonement, the work of Christ in dealing with sin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities" (Isaiah 53:5).
2. "The LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Isaiah 53:6).
3. "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus" (Romans 3:23-24).
4. "Whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith" (Romans 3:25).

5. “This was to show God’s righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins” (Romans 3:25).
6. “That he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus” (Romans 3:26).
7. “He entered once for all into the holy places, not by means of the blood of goats and calves but by means of his own blood, thus securing an eternal redemption” (Hebrews 9:12).
8. “Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins” (Hebrews 9:22).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The atonement is the work of Christ on the cross by which sinners are reconciled to God. The word itself means “at-one-ment,” the making of peace between two parties who were estranged. The Bible uses several pictures to describe what happened, and each adds something.

The first is sacrifice. In the Old Testament, an animal died in the place of the sinner, and its blood covered the guilt. Hebrews says that these sacrifices were a shadow. They could not take away sins, which is why they had to be repeated. Christ offered himself once for all, a perfect sacrifice. The second is substitution. Isaiah 53 says the Servant bore our iniquities and was pierced for our transgressions. He took our place. The penalty we deserved fell on him. This is sometimes called penal substitution: he bore the penalty in our place.

The third is propitiation. Romans 3:25 says God put forward Christ as a propitiation, a sacrifice that satisfies God’s righteous wrath against sin. This is not a picture of an angry God being calmed by a loving Son. It is God himself who puts forward the sacrifice, out of love. The Father, Son, and Spirit were united in this work. The fourth is redemption. A ransom price was paid to buy slaves out of bondage. Christ’s blood is the price (Mark 10:45; 1 Peter 1:18-19). The fifth is victory. Colossians 2:15 says that on the cross Christ triumphed over the rulers and authorities.

Romans 3:26 states the great puzzle that the cross solves: how can God be both just and the justifier of the ungodly? He cannot simply ignore sin, for he is righteous. The cross shows that he does not ignore it. The penalty is paid. And so God can freely forgive those who trust in Christ.

For believers, the atonement is the ground of our assurance. Our standing before God does not depend on our performance. It depends on what Christ has finished.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages work like three voices in harmony. Isaiah gives the story in prophetic language. A righteous Servant suffers for others, though he did nothing wrong. The language is of sin-bearing and healing. “The LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all.” Notice that the Father is the one who lays it on him. This was not an accident or a tragedy. “It was the will of the LORD to crush him.” It was God’s plan, carried out in love.

Paul explains why this had to happen. All have sinned, and there is no distinction. No one can earn a place before God. But God offers justification as a gift. To justify means to declare righteous, a legal term. We are not made righteous by our deeds. God declares us righteous because of what Christ has done. This is received by faith, not earned. Paul also says that God “passed over former sins” in his forbearance, meaning that before the cross he had been patient with sin. The cross shows that this patience was not indifference. The debt was real, and it was finally paid.

Hebrews approaches it through the temple. The old high priest entered the Holy of Holies once a year with the blood of animals. Christ, by contrast, entered heaven itself with his own blood, once for all, “securing an eternal redemption.” The old covenant’s sacrifices only cleansed the flesh. Christ’s blood “purifies our conscience from dead works to serve the living God.” And he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance. Because he is both priest and sacrifice, nothing more needs to be offered.

Put together, these texts show that the cross was necessary, because sin is serious and God is just. It was sufficient, because Christ’s offering was perfect. And it was personal. The Servant bore “our” sins, and Christ gave himself “for me” (Galatians 2:20).

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 10:45 says Christ came to give his life as a ransom for many. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says, “For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.” Galatians 3:13 says Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us. 1 John 2:2 and 4:10 speak of him as the propitiation for our sins. Ephesians 1:7 says that in him we have redemption through his blood. Hebrews 10:14 says that by a single offering he has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified.

STEP 6

Application

Write down, in your own words, what Christ did on the cross for you. Use at least two of the pictures: sacrifice, substitution, ransom, victory.

Rest in the finished work. Ask where you are still trying to earn what has been given.

Share one of these truths with someone who is weighed down by guilt.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank the Father for laying on his Son the iniquity of all.

Thank Jesus for bearing your sins.

Tell God how you want to live in light of the cross.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 410 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 54:1-57:21

Covenant expanded; "come, everyone who thirsts"

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 54:1-57:21. After the cross of chapter 53 comes the fruit: a barren woman sings, the covenant is widened, and everyone who thirsts is invited to come. Read Isaiah 55 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 54 follows directly from the Servant's death. Because the Servant gave himself, Zion, a woman barren and desolate, will have many children. The following chapters broaden the invitation. The gate is opened to foreigners and eunuchs who were once excluded. The covenant now rests on grace. And the section ends with a warning that there is no peace for the wicked.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Sing, O barren one, who did not bear; break forth into singing and cry aloud" (54:1).
2. "For a brief moment I deserted you, but with great compassion I will gather you" (54:7).
3. "For the mountains may depart and the hills be removed, but my steadfast love shall not depart from you" (54:10).
4. "No weapon that is fashioned against you shall succeed" (54:17).
5. "Come, everyone who thirsts, come to the waters; and he who has no money, come, buy and eat!" (55:1).
6. "Seek the LORD while he may be found; call upon him while he is near" (55:6).
7. "For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the LORD" (55:8).

8 “So shall my word be that goes out from my mouth; it shall not return to me empty” (55:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The command to sing in chapter 54 is startling. The one addressed is a barren woman, and yet she is told to sing, for the children of the desolate will be more than those of the married. The cross has made this possible. Because the Servant was cut off from the land of the living, many are born. The promises that follow are tender. God is her husband, her redeemer. He admits that for a moment he forsook her in his anger, but with everlasting love he has compassion. And he swears, as in the days of Noah, that he will not be angry with her again. The mountains may depart, but his love will not.

Chapter 55 is one of the greatest invitations in the Bible. “Come, everyone who thirsts.” It is free: “He who has no money, come, buy and eat… without money and without price.” The paradox of buying without money states the nature of grace. The question: “Why do you spend your money for that which is not bread, and your labor for that which does not satisfy?” It describes the empty pursuits of the world. God offers an everlasting covenant, the “sure mercies of David,” now extended to all.

The call is urgent: “Seek the LORD while he may be found.” It includes a call to repentance: “Let the wicked forsake his way… let him return to the LORD, that he may have compassion on him, and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon.” The reason for confidence is that God’s ways are higher than ours: “As the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways.” This is not a statement of distance but of generosity. His pardon is greater than we think possible. And his word is effective, like rain that waters the earth. It does not return empty.

Chapter 56 is a surprising word of inclusion. Foreigners and eunuchs, who were barred from the assembly in the law, are welcomed. “My house shall be called a house of prayer for all peoples.” Chapter 57 then contrasts the contrite and humble, with whom God dwells, to the wicked, who have no peace.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37) and to the woman at the well offered living water (John 4:10-14). Revelation 22:17 invites, “Let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who desires take the water of life without price.” Jesus quoted Isaiah

56:7 when he cleansed the temple (Mark 11:17). Galatians 4:27 quotes Isaiah 54:1. Acts 13:34 quotes “the sure mercies of David” as fulfilled in Christ’s resurrection. Matthew 5:3 echoes “the poor in spirit” of Isaiah 57:15.

STEP 6

Application

Accept Isaiah 55:1 as an invitation. What are you spending on “that which is not bread”? Bring that thirst to God.

Welcome someone who has been left out of your circle, as God welcomed the foreigner and the eunuch.

Trust the word you read, as rain that waters the earth and will not return empty.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are thirsty for.
- Confess where you have spent your labor on what does not satisfy.
- Ask him to help you seek him while he may be found.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

“But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed.”

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 411 · WEEK 59

Psalm 22

From the horns of the wild oxen you have rescued me

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22. You have read parts of this psalm twice before in earlier units. Read it again now with Isaiah 53 open beside it. Both describe a righteous sufferer who is forsaken, pierced, and then vindicated, so that the nations turn to the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is a psalm of David, and the Gospels show Jesus praying its first line from the cross. Paired with the fourth Servant Song, it shows the suffering and glory that the Old Testament predicts for the Messiah. Notice especially the second half, in which the sufferer is delivered and the result is worldwide worship. That is the same pattern as Isaiah 53:10-12.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from saving me?” (v. 1).
2. “But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people” (v. 6).
3. “All who see me mock me; they make mouths at me; they wag their heads” (v. 7).
4. “They have pierced my hands and feet” (v. 16).
5. “They divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots” (v. 18).
6. “You who fear the LORD, praise him! … For he has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted” (vv. 23-24).
7. “All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD, and all the families of the nations shall worship before you” (v. 27).

8 “They shall come and proclaim his righteousness to a people yet unborn, that he has done it” (v. 31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Read beside Isaiah 53, the psalm reveals the same shape. The Servant is despised and rejected, and the psalmist is “a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind.” The Servant is silent before his accusers, and the psalmist is surrounded by bulls, lions, and dogs. The Servant is pierced and crushed, and the psalmist’s bones are out of joint, his heart like wax, his strength dried up. Even his clothes are divided. And then in both, the turn.

In Isaiah 53:10-11, “he shall see his offspring; he shall prolong his days… out of the anguish of his soul he shall see and be satisfied.” In Psalm 22:21-22, the sufferer is heard and begins to declare God’s name to his brothers and praise him in the congregation. The suffering was not the end.

Verses 24 to 31 are the surprising conclusion. God “has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted, and he has not hidden his face from him, but has heard, when he cried to him.” The cry of dereliction is answered. And its effect is global: “All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD.” The affliction of one man brings all nations to worship. “The poor shall eat and be satisfied.” Compare Isaiah 53:11, “make many to be accounted righteous,” and Isaiah 49:6, a light for the nations.

The psalm ends with the future generations: “They shall come and proclaim his righteousness to a people yet unborn, that he has done it.” The Hebrew for “that he has done it” is a single word, much like Jesus’ cry, “It is finished.”

Why is it here? Because Isaiah’s Servant is not an abstract idea. Real suffering is involved, in real flesh. The psalm gives the Servant a voice. It shows what he felt: abandonment, mockery, thirst, and yet, trust, and ultimately praise. Because of this, Christians in suffering have a companion in the one who prayed this psalm to the end.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus cried, “Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani” on the cross (Matthew 27:46), and the details of Psalm 22 are found throughout the passion narratives: mocking (Matthew 27:39-43), the dividing of garments (John 19:23-24), thirst (John 19:28). Hebrews 2:12 puts verse 22 on Jesus’ lips. Revelation 7:9 shows people from all nations worshiping. John 19:30 records “It is finished.” Romans 8:34 says Christ is at the right hand of God, interceding.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud as Jesus' prayer. Thank him for walking through abandonment so that you never have to be abandoned.

If you feel forsaken, pray verse 1 honestly, and then continue reading to verse 24.

Pray for a nation or people group that has not heard the gospel, using verse 27.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he did not despise the affliction of his Son.

Thank Jesus for crying out in forsakenness for you.

Ask him to make you tell others of what he has done.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 412 · WEEK 59

Psalm 69:1-21

Save me, O God; reproach has broken my heart

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 69:1-21. It is a cry of deep suffering from one who is hated for the sake of God. Notice how often the New Testament quotes this psalm.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 69 is a psalm of David. It is one of the most quoted psalms in the New Testament, second only to Psalm 22. The psalmist is sinking in deep waters, exhausted from crying, and hated without cause. What makes his suffering unusual is that it comes because of his zeal for God. It pairs well with Isaiah's Servant, who suffered on behalf of others. It will appear again in Unit 18 with a different focus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Save me, O God! For the waters have come up to my neck" (v. 1).
2. "I sink in deep mire, where there is no foothold" (v. 2).
3. "More in number than the hairs of my head are those who hate me without cause" (v. 4).
4. "What I did not steal must I now restore?" (v. 4).
5. "For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach, that dishonor has covered my face" (v. 7).
6. "I have become a stranger to my brothers, an alien to my mother's sons" (v. 8).
7. "For zeal for your house has consumed me, and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me" (v. 9).
8. "They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink" (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening images are those of drowning: deep waters, mire, floods. The psalmist is worn out with calling for help, his throat parched, his eyes failing from waiting for God. The suffering is intense, and it appears to come from several sources: false accusations, the loss of family, the mockery of those at the gate and the drunkards' songs.

The unusual feature is the reason for it. "For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach." His loyalty to God has made him a target. His zeal for God's house has consumed him, and the insults aimed at God have landed on him. He has fasted and wept, and been mocked for it. There is no sense that the suffering is deserved. Though he acknowledges that he is not without folly (v. 5), the accusation against him is false.

The prayer turns on God's steadfast love. "But as for me, my prayer is to you, O LORD. At an acceptable time, O God, in the abundance of your steadfast love answer me." He asks God to rescue him from the mire, and he appeals to God's goodness: "Answer me, O LORD, for your steadfast love is good; according to your abundant mercy, turn to me." Then comes the heartbreaking description of verses 20 and 21: "Reproaches have broken my heart, so that I am in despair. I looked for pity, but there was none, and for comforters, but I found none. They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink."

This psalm helps us see the Servant's suffering from the inside. The Servant is despised and rejected, with no one to comfort him. Yet the psalm leaves us with a question: what should the sufferer do? His answer is to pray. He does not repay hatred with hatred but brings his anguish to God. For the believer who suffers for righteousness' sake, the psalm is a guide and a comfort.

STEP 5

Connection

John 2:17 quotes verse 9, "Zeal for your house will consume me," when Jesus cleansed the temple. John 15:25 quotes verse 4, "They hated me without a cause." Romans 15:3 quotes verse 9, "The reproaches of those who reproached you fell on me," about Christ. Matthew 27:34, 48 and John 19:28-29 record the sour wine on the cross. Acts 1:20 quotes verse 25 in connection with Judas. 1 Peter 4:14 says that if we are insulted for the name of Christ, we are blessed.

STEP 6

Application

If you are suffering for doing right, bring it to God in honest prayer, and do not repay evil for evil.

Ask for the same zeal for God's house that Jesus had, a love for the church that is real and costly.

Look for someone who has "looked for pity and found none." Be the comforter.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God about what overwhelms you.
- Thank Jesus for the zeal that consumed him.
- Ask him to teach you to bear reproach for his sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 413 · WEEK 59

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 53:5 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

REST

Meditation

This is the heart of the Old Testament's picture of the cross. It was written some seven centuries before Jesus was born, and it describes what he would do in language that is hard to read without wonder.

"But he was pierced for our transgressions." The word "pierced" means run through, wounded to the point of death. The Servant's wounds are connected to something: our transgressions. The sin was ours. The piercing was his. "He was crushed for our iniquities." The word "crushed" is the strongest word for breaking something to pieces. Iniquity is twisted behavior. Each phrase is a transfer. What belonged to us was borne by him.

"Upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace." Chastisement is discipline, the punishment that was due. It fell on him, and the result is peace for us. Think about what this peace is: not just a feeling of calm, but reconciliation with God. The war between a holy God

and a rebellious people has ended.

“And with his wounds we are healed.” The healing is the forgiveness of sins and the restoration of the whole person. 1 Peter 2:24 says that “by his wounds you have been healed.” The wounds that made him unrecognizable are the means of our wholeness. The scars of Christ are the glory of the gospel.

This verse can be said at any time. When you feel guilt, say it. When you are tempted to believe that you must earn God’s favor, say it. When you meet someone who has no hope, tell them. The Servant was wounded for us, and the debt is paid.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through the center of Isaiah. You saw the idols of Babylon carried off on animals, while the true God carries his people from birth to old age. You heard the Servant speak, call him to be a light for the nations, and learned that God has engraved his people on the palms of his hands. Then you came to the heart of the book: the Servant who gave his back to those who strike, who was despised and rejected, pierced for our transgressions, and crushed for our iniquities. On Wednesday’s doctrinal pause you traced the doctrine of the atonement through sacrifice, substitution, propitiation, redemption, and victory. After the cross came the invitation of Isaiah 55, “Come, everyone who thirsts.” And you prayed Psalms 22 and 69, in which the suffering Messiah speaks for himself. The week taught that Jesus bore our sins, that God is both just and the justifier, and that the invitation is free.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah 53 says the Servant was pierced for our transgressions. What does it mean to you personally that Jesus took your place?

The doctrinal pause described the atonement through several pictures. Which one speaks most clearly to your own need right now: sacrifice, substitution, ransom, or victory?

Isaiah 55 invites everyone who thirsts to come without money. What would it mean for you to accept this invitation without trying to earn it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he was pierced and crushed for you.

Thank him that by his wounds you are healed.

Rest in the peace he bought.

DAY 414 · WEEK 60

Isaiah 58:1-60:22

True fasting; the Spirit's anointing; Zion's future glory

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 58:1-60:22. God describes the fast he wants, the Servant speaks about the Spirit's anointing, and the future glory of Zion shines like sunrise. Read chapter 58 as a challenge, and chapter 60 as a promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last section of Isaiah, chapters 56 to 66, addresses a community that has begun to return from exile, or is on the verge of it, and finds the promised glory slow to appear. The people ask why God does not notice their fasting. The answer is that religion without justice is empty. Then the section moves on to the Spirit-anointed one, a new covenant, and a future in which the nations stream to the light of Zion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Cry aloud; do not hold back; lift up your voice like a trumpet; declare to my people their transgression" (58:1).
2. "Is not this the fast that I choose: to loose the bonds of wickedness, to undo the straps of the yoke, to let the oppressed go free?" (58:6).
3. "Is it not to share your bread with the hungry and bring the homeless poor into your house?" (58:7).
4. "Then shall your light break forth like the dawn, and your healing shall spring up speedily" (58:8).
5. "Behold, the LORD's hand is not shortened, that it cannot save... but your iniquities have made a separation between you and your God" (59:1-2).

6. “He saw that there was no man, and wondered that there was no one to intercede; then his own arm brought him salvation” (59:16).
7. “And a Redeemer will come to Zion, to those in Jacob who turn from transgression” (59:20).
8. “Arise, shine, for your light has come, and the glory of the LORD has risen upon you” (60:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 58 begins with a surprise. The people seem religious, “seeking” God daily, delighting to know his ways. They fast, and they wonder why God does not see. God answers that on the day of their fast they pursue their own interests and oppress their workers. They fast with quarreling and strife. A day of bowing the head like a reed is not what God wants. The fast that he chooses is to set the oppressed free, share bread with the hungry, shelter the homeless, and clothe the naked. This is Isaiah 1 again. True worship cannot be separated from compassion.

The promise attached to this obedience is wonderful. “Then shall your light break forth like the dawn.” “You shall be like a watered garden.” And the Sabbath is also mentioned: delight in it, and God will cause you to ride on the heights of the earth.

Chapter 59 turns to the problem beneath. The LORD’s hand is not too short to save. It is sin that separates. The chapter is a bleak confession of corporate guilt: “Our transgressions are multiplied before you.” Justice is turned back, truth stumbles in the street. “He saw that there was no man… then his own arm brought him salvation.” God himself, a divine warrior, puts on righteousness as a breastplate and the helmet of salvation. “And a Redeemer will come to Zion.” A new covenant is promised: “My Spirit that is upon you, and my words that I have put in your mouth, shall not depart.”

Chapter 60 is a wave of light. Darkness covers the earth, but the LORD rises over Zion, and nations come to her light. Kings come to the brightness of her rising. Her gates are open continually. The sun and moon are replaced by the LORD as an everlasting light. “Your people shall all be righteous; they shall possess the land forever.” The people who were exiles become a glorious city.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Whatever you did for one of the least of these, you did for me” (Matthew 25:35-40). James 1:27 and 2:14-17 echo the call to practical compassion. Paul uses the armor of Isaiah 59:17 in Ephesians 6:14-17. Romans 11:26-27 quotes Isaiah 59:20-21 about the

Redeemer. Jesus said, “I am the light of the world” (John 8:12), and Revelation 21:23-25 shows the city lit by the glory of God, its gates never shut, and the nations walking by its light.

STEP 6

Application

Choose one concrete act of justice or mercy: share a meal, give to the poor, or help someone out of a hard situation.

Ask how your spiritual practices, such as fasting, prayer, and church, affect how you treat people.

Let the light of Christ shine in a dark place this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you the fast he chooses, and ask how you can share bread with the hungry.

Confess where your religion has been empty.

Ask him to let your light rise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 415 · WEEK 60

Isaiah 61:1-63:14

The year of the LORD's favor; the divine warrior

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 61:1-63:14. In chapter 61 an anointed one announces good news, which Jesus read aloud in the synagogue at Nazareth. Then comes a vision of a divine warrior and a long memory of the exodus. Read 61:1-3 as if you were in that synagogue.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah 61 is a text that Jesus chose to read at the beginning of his public ministry (Luke 4:16-21). It describes an anointed herald who announces release to captives. Chapter 62 speaks of Zion's new name and of God's delight in her as a bridegroom delights in his bride. Chapter 63 opens with a figure coming from Edom in blood-stained garments, treading the winepress of wrath, and ends with a remembrance of God's saving acts in the exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Spirit of the Lord GOD is upon me, because the LORD has anointed me to bring good news to the poor" (61:1).
2. "To proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to those who are bound" (61:1).
3. "To proclaim the year of the LORD's favor, and the day of vengeance of our God" (61:2).
4. "To grant to those who mourn in Zion… a beautiful headdress instead of ashes, the oil of gladness instead of mourning" (61:3).
5. "I will greatly rejoice in the LORD; my soul shall exult in my God, for he has clothed me with the garments of salvation" (61:10).
6. "You shall be called by a new name that the mouth of the LORD will give" (62:2).

7. “As the bridegroom rejoices over the bride, so shall your God rejoice over you” (62:5).
8. “In all their affliction he was afflicted, and the angel of his presence saved them; in his love and in his pity he redeemed them” (63:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The speaker of chapter 61 is the Servant, now described as anointed with the Spirit. He is a prophet, a king, and a priest. His mission is a series of reversals: good news to the poor, binding up the brokenhearted, liberty for captives, comfort for those who mourn. The promise is of a jubilee, a year of release. The imagery is of the Year of Jubilee in Leviticus 25, when debts were forgiven and slaves went free. The beautiful exchanges are: a crown instead of ashes, gladness instead of mourning, a garment of praise instead of a faint spirit.

When Jesus read this passage in Nazareth, he stopped in the middle of verse 2, after “the year of the LORD’s favor.” He omitted the phrase “and the day of vengeance of our God.” Then he said, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing.” The first coming brings the favor, and the second will bring the vengeance. The two parts are separated by the time of the church.

Chapter 62 expresses God’s passion for his people. He will not keep silent until her righteousness shines like the dawn. She will be called by a new name, “My Delight Is in Her.” “As the bridegroom rejoices over the bride, so shall your God rejoice over you.” This is the language of marriage, as in Hosea. The divine bridegroom delights in his people. Watchmen are posted on the walls who will give God no rest until he makes Jerusalem a praise in the earth.

Chapter 63 begins with a terrifying warrior coming from Edom. His garments are stained red, for he has trodden the winepress alone. It is a picture of God’s judgment on his enemies. Then the prophet looks back with gratitude and prays, remembering the exodus. “In all their affliction he was afflicted.” God suffers with his people. But they rebelled and grieved his Holy Spirit. Even so, the Spirit led them, “like livestock that go down into the valley,” to give them rest.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus announced in Luke 4:18-21 that Isaiah 61 was fulfilled in him. He answered John the Baptist with these signs (Luke 7:22). Matthew 5:4 says, “Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted.” Ephesians 5:25-27 shows Christ as the bridegroom who presents the

church to himself in splendor. Revelation 19:13-15 draws on the warrior with the stained garment, and verse 7 speaks of the marriage of the Lamb. Ephesians 4:30 echoes “do not grieve the Holy Spirit.”

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 61:1-3 as a description of your calling in Christ, and see where you can bring good news to someone who is poor, broken, or bound.

Receive the exchange: ask Jesus to give you a crown instead of ashes and the oil of gladness instead of mourning.

Rest in the truth that God rejoices over you, as a bridegroom over a bride.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for bringing good news to the poor and binding up the brokenhearted.
- Tell him what you want him to bind up in you.
- Thank him for the year of favor.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 416 · WEEK 60

Isaiah 63:15-66:24

Lament and prayer; new creation, the grand finale

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 63:15-66:24. The book ends with a desperate prayer for God to tear open the heavens, an answer that announces a new heavens and a new earth, and a final scene of worship and warning. Read chapter 65 slowly. It is the great finale of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last part of Isaiah opens with one of the most heartfelt prayers in the Old Testament. The people confess their sin, plead for God to act, and ask for the heavens to be torn open. God replies with a promise of new creation, a place where the LORD's people live in peace and joy, with long life and no tears. The book closes with a contrast between those who tremble at God's word and those who do not.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For you are our Father, though Abraham does not know us, and Israel does not acknowledge us; you, O LORD, are our Father, our Redeemer from of old is your name" (63:16).
2. "Oh that you would rend the heavens and come down, that the mountains might quake at your presence" (64:1).
3. "We have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment" (64:6).
4. "But now, O LORD, you are our Father; we are the clay, and you are our potter; we are all the work of your hand" (64:8).
5. "Before they call I will answer; while they are yet speaking I will hear" (65:24).

6. “For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind” (65:17).
7. “No more shall there be in it an infant who lives but a few days” (65:20).
8. “But this is the one to whom I will look: he who is humble and contrite in spirit and trembles at my word” (66:2).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The prayer of 63:15 to 64:12 is the plea of a people who feel far from God. They look back to the exodus and ask where God’s zeal has gone. “You, O LORD, are our Father.” Their earthly fathers may not know them, but God does. They confess that they have strayed: “Why, O LORD, do you make us wander from your ways and harden our heart?” And the prayer climbs toward a cry: “Oh that you would rend the heavens and come down!” They want God to appear as he did at Sinai.

Then comes the confession of 64:6: “We have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment.” It is a startling statement. Even our best deeds, apart from God, are stained. No one calls on his name or rouses himself to take hold of God. And then the prayer rests on a relationship: “But now, O LORD, you are our Father; we are the clay, and you are our potter.” If God shapes us, we can trust the shaping.

God’s answer in chapter 65 begins with a rebuke, because he was ready to be sought by a people who did not ask. “I said, Here am I, here am I, to a nation that was not called by my name.” Yet he will preserve a remnant, his servants, who will inherit. And the grand promise: “I create new heavens and a new earth.” The vision includes Jerusalem as a joy, with no weeping, no early deaths, no frustrated labor. “They shall build houses and inhabit them; they shall plant vineyards and eat their fruit.” The wolf and the lamb feed together again.

Chapter 66 emphasizes humility. The temple cannot contain God, and he looks to the one who is humble and contrite and trembles at his word. The book ends with a vision of all nations coming to worship, and a sober picture of the fate of rebels. “All flesh shall come to worship before me.” The last note is a warning, so that the reader will choose well.

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 1:10 describes the heavens being torn open at Jesus’ baptism, an answer to Isaiah 64:1. Romans 10:20-21 quotes Isaiah 65:1-2 about God’s welcome to the Gentiles. 2 Peter 3:13 and Revelation 21:1-4 describe the new heavens and new earth, with God dwelling with his

people and wiping away every tear. Romans 9:21 draws on the potter and the clay. Philippians 3:9 says our righteousness comes from God by faith. Jesus quotes Isaiah 66:24 in Mark 9:48.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Isaiah 64:8 as your own: “You are the potter; I am the clay.” Ask him to keep shaping you.

Consider where you still depend on your “righteous deeds.” Rest in Christ’s righteousness.

Meditate on the new creation. Ask God to make you long for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Call on God as Father and Redeemer.
- Confess that your righteous deeds are like a polluted garment, and tell him whom you trust.
- Thank him for the new heavens and new earth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 417 · WEEK 60

Nahum 1:1-3:19

Nineveh falls, God's patience exhausted

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nahum 1:1-3:19. Nahum is a short prophecy of about fifty verses against Nineveh, the Assyrian capital. This is the same city that repented under Jonah. Read it with Jonah in mind, and ask what has changed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Nahum prophesied in the seventh century BC, sometime after the fall of Thebes in 663 BC and before the fall of Nineveh in 612 BC. A hundred and fifty years earlier, Nineveh had repented at Jonah's preaching. In the generations since, the city returned to violence and cruelty and became the capital of the empire that destroyed Samaria and tormented Judah. Nahum's message is that God's patience, though long, has an end.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD is a jealous and avenging God; the LORD is avenging and wrathful" (1:2).
2. "The LORD is slow to anger and great in power, and the LORD will by no means clear the guilty" (1:3).
3. "The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him" (1:7).
4. "Behold, on the mountains, the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace!" (1:15).
5. "Woe to the bloody city, all full of lies and plunder" (3:1).
6. "Behold, I am against you, declares the LORD of hosts" (3:5).
7. "There is no easing your hurt; your wound is grievous" (3:19).

8 “For upon whom has not come your unceasing evil?” (3:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with a majestic hymn about God’s character, drawing on Exodus 34:6-7. But Nahum emphasizes a different side. He quotes “slow to anger” and then, “will by no means clear the guilty.” God’s patience is not indifference. A holy God must respond to evil. The imagery is of a storm: mountains quake, hills melt, the earth heaves. Who can stand before his indignation? And in the middle, a note of gentle comfort: “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.” To the same God, the wicked experience a fire, and the faithful a refuge. Everything depends on which side of him we stand.

The word to Judah in 1:12-15 is a comfort: “Though I have afflicted you, I will afflict you no more.” The yoke of Assyria will be broken. And the herald appears on the mountains with good news. Isaiah 52:7 uses the same image, which Paul applies to the preaching of the gospel in Romans 10:15.

Chapters 2 and 3 describe the fall of Nineveh with vivid military imagery: shields red, chariots flashing, the river gates opening, the palace dissolving. In 612 BC, the city fell when the Tigris flooded and broke part of the wall, and the Babylonians and Medes entered. The prophet describes the city as a den of lions that fed on prey and filled its caves with plunder. “Behold, I am against you.” Her sins are violence, deceit, plunder, and sorceries. She will be exposed, shamed, and no one will mourn.

The book ends with a rhetorical question that reminds us of Jonah: “For upon whom has not come your unceasing evil?” The contrast with the book of Jonah is a lesson. In Jonah’s day, the city repented and was spared. In Nahum’s day, the city had returned to evil and was not spared. God’s mercy is real, and God’s justice is real. Both come from the same character. No generation can live on the repentance of a previous one.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 11:22 says, “Note then the kindness and the severity of God.” Romans 10:15 applies Nahum 1:15 to those who bring the gospel. Jesus’ comparison in Matthew 12:41 says the men of Nineveh will rise at the judgment. 2 Peter 3:9 says the Lord is patient, not wishing that any should perish, and verse 10 says the day of the Lord will come. Hebrews 12:29 says our God is a consuming fire. Psalm 34:8 invites us to taste and see that the LORD is good.

STEP 6

Application

Take refuge in the LORD, who is good, and thank him that you are known by him.

Ask whether you are presuming on God's patience in any area.

Pray for a violent or oppressive regime in the world today, that justice would come and the oppressed would be freed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is slow to anger and great in power.

Thank him that he is a stronghold and knows those who take refuge in him.

Pray for those who suffer under cruelty.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!"

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 418 · WEEK 60

Habakkuk 1:1-3:19

The just shall live by faith, wrestling with God's ways

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Habakkuk 1:1-3:19. Habakkuk does something unusual for a prophet: he argues with God. Read it as a conversation. Notice how the prophet's questions change, and where the book ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Habakkuk prophesied in Judah around 610 to 600 BC, probably in the days of King Jehoiakim, when the Assyrian empire was collapsing and Babylon was rising. Judah was full of violence and injustice. Habakkuk cries out to God, and God's answer disturbs him even more. The book is a dialogue between a troubled believer and a sovereign God. It ends with one of the greatest expressions of faith in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, how long shall I cry for help, and you will not hear? Or cry to you Violence! and you will not save?" (1:2).
2. "Look among the nations, and see; wonder and be astounded. For I am doing a work in your days that you would not believe if told" (1:5).
3. "For behold, I am raising up the Chaldeans" (1:6).
4. "You who are of purer eyes than to see evil and cannot look at wrong, why do you idly look at traitors?" (1:13).
5. "I will take my stand at my watchpost... and look out to see what he will say to me" (2:1).
6. "Behold, his soul is puffed up; it is not upright within him, but the righteous shall live by his faith" (2:4).

7. “For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD as the waters cover the sea” (2:14).

8. “Though the fig tree should not blossom… yet I will rejoice in the LORD; I will take joy in the God of my salvation” (3:17-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Habakkuk’s first complaint is that God is silent in the face of violence in Judah. God answers that he is raising up the Chaldeans, the Babylonians, a fierce and dreadful nation. This is not the answer Habakkuk wanted. He asks a second question: How can a holy God use a nation more wicked than Judah to punish them? “You who are of purer eyes than to see evil… why do you look at traitors and remain silent when the wicked swallows up the man more righteous than he?” It is an honest, hard question about God’s justice and his ways.

Habakkuk then takes his stand like a watchman and waits. God replies, and tells him to write the vision plainly. It will surely come, though it seems slow. And at the center of the answer is the verse that changed history: “The righteous shall live by his faith.” The proud, puffed-up man depends on himself. The righteous person depends on God, and lives by trust in him, even when the answer seems to be delay.

The rest of chapter 2 contains five woes against the Babylonians, those who plunder, build their house by injustice, build cities with blood, make others drunk, and trust in idols. They will fall. “But the LORD is in his holy temple; let all the earth keep silence before him.” It is a verse that stills the questions.

Chapter 3 is a prayer, set to music, that recalls God’s great acts in the exodus and at Sinai. Habakkuk sees God coming in splendor, with light and pestilence. He trembles. And then comes the glorious conclusion: “Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be on the vines… yet I will rejoice in the LORD.” He lists every kind of agricultural disaster, a picture of complete economic collapse. And still he rejoices. Faith does not depend on circumstances. “God, the Lord, is my strength; he makes my feet like the deer’s; he makes me tread on my high places.” The prophet who began in doubt ends in joy.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4 in Romans 1:17 and Galatians 3:11, and the author of Hebrews quotes it in Hebrews 10:38. It became the foundation text of the Reformation. Habakkuk 2:14 echoes Isaiah 11:9. Romans 8:28 and 8:35-39 give a New Testament answer to Habakkuk’s questions: nothing can separate us from the love of God. Philippians 4:11-13 shows Paul’s contentment in every circumstance. James 1:2-4 calls us to count it joy when we meet trials.

STEP 6

Application

Bring your hardest question to God in prayer. Habakkuk shows that honest questions are welcome.

Take your “stand at the watchpost.” Set aside time to listen after you have prayed.

Write out your own version of Habakkuk 3:17-18, naming real things that could be taken from you, and say you will still rejoice in the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring God your honest questions.
- Ask him to teach you to live by faith.
- Tell him you will rejoice in him even when things are barren.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 419 · WEEK 60

Zephaniah 1:1-3:20

The Day of the LORD; the LORD rejoices over his people

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zephaniah 1:1-3:20. The last of this unit's prophets begins with a terrifying announcement of the Day of the LORD and ends with one of the most tender images of God in the Bible. Read the last four verses twice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Zephaniah prophesied in the days of King Josiah, around 640 to 609 BC, before Josiah's reforms took hold. His great-grandfather was Hezekiah, so he may have been of royal blood. The book is built around the phrase "the day of the LORD." It begins with a universal judgment, calls Judah to repent, speaks against the nations, and ends with restoration. It prepares the way for the exile that is coming.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will utterly sweep away everything from the face of the earth, declares the LORD" (1:2).
2. "The great day of the LORD is near, near and hastening fast" (1:14).
3. "Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land, who do his just commands; seek righteousness; seek humility; perhaps you may be hidden on the day of the anger of the LORD" (2:3).
4. "Woe to her who is rebellious and defiled, the oppressing city!" (3:1).
5. "She listens to no voice; she accepts no correction. She does not trust in the LORD; she does not draw near to her God" (3:2).

6. “For at that time I will change the speech of the peoples to a pure speech, that all of them may call upon the name of the LORD” (3:9).

7. “But I will leave in your midst a people humble and lowly. They shall seek refuge in the name of the LORD” (3:12).

8. “The LORD your God is in your midst, a mighty one who will save; he will rejoice over you with gladness; he will quiet you by his love; he will exult over you with loud singing” (3:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first chapter is relentless. God will sweep away everything: man and beast, birds and fish. The reason is idolatry and spiritual indifference. The people worship Baal and the host of heaven, and others say in their hearts, “The LORD will not do good, nor will he do ill.” They are practical atheists who believe that God does nothing. God will search Jerusalem with lamps. The day is described as a day of wrath, distress, ruin, darkness, and gloom. Not even silver or gold can deliver them.

Then chapter 2 begins with a call: “Gather yourselves together… before the decree takes effect… seek the LORD, all you humble of the land.” The only protection is humility and a search for righteousness. “Perhaps you may be hidden.” The word “perhaps” reminds us that no one deserves to be saved. Yet the invitation is real. The remaining part of the chapter pronounces judgment on Philistia, Moab, Ammon, Cush, and Assyria. Nineveh will be a desolation.

Chapter 3 returns to Jerusalem, “the oppressing city,” which did not listen or trust. Officials are roaring lions, judges evening wolves, prophets reckless and treacherous, priests profane the sanctuary. “The LORD within her is righteous; he does no injustice.” God had hoped that she would learn, but she was eager to make her deeds corrupt.

And then the turn, “For at that time.” The nations will call on the name of the LORD. A humble and lowly remnant will be left, who do no injustice and speak no lies. They will lie down with none to make them afraid. Then the song: “Sing aloud, O daughter of Zion.” The reason is verse 17, one of the most beautiful verses in the Old Testament. The LORD is in your midst, a warrior who saves. He rejoices over you with gladness. “He will quiet you by his love.” He sings over you. The God who judged is the God who sings. The same hand that sweeps away the proud gathers the humble.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the one in the midst of his people who saves (Matthew 1:21; 18:20). Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ, who have been hidden on the day of wrath. Luke 15:5-7 and 15:20-24 show heaven rejoicing over sinners who return. Hebrews 12:22-24 describes the gathered assembly of the firstborn. Revelation 7:9-17 shows the multitude from every nation, with God wiping away tears. 1 Thessalonians 1:10 says Jesus delivers us from the wrath to come.

STEP 6

Application

Read Zephaniah 3:17 aloud, replacing "you" with your own name, and sit in it for a few minutes.

Ask whether you ever live as if "the LORD will not do good, nor will he do ill," as a practical atheist.

Pray for humility, the posture that Zephaniah says leads to being hidden.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to hide you in the day of his anger.
- Tell him you seek righteousness and humility.
- Thank him that he rejoices over you with singing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!"

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 420 · WEEK 60

Review and Sabbath Rest

Unit 12 review, Hezekiah, Isaiah & the Assyrian Crisis

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Review and Sabbath

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!"
>
> ISAIAH 6:3

REST

Meditation

This is the cry of the seraphim in Isaiah's vision, and it is the anchor of the whole unit. Everything you have read, from the vineyard song to the suffering Servant to the fall of Nineveh, flows from who God is. He is holy.

"Holy, holy, holy." Hebrew has no way to say "more" or "most." Instead it repeats. To say a word three times is to say it as strongly as language can. Only this one attribute of God is ever repeated three times in the Bible. He is utterly set apart, in power, in purity, and in glory. All other things that we call holy are holy because they are connected to him.

"Is the LORD of hosts." The holy one is not an abstract force. He is the LORD, the covenant God who has a name and who keeps promises. He is also the Lord of hosts, the commander of the armies of heaven. The one who stands against Assyria is the one who reigns over every power.

"The whole earth is full of his glory." The seraphim see glory in every corner of creation. God's glory is not limited to the temple. It fills the whole earth. Later in Isaiah, we learn that the knowledge of that glory will cover the earth as the waters cover the sea, and that all flesh will see it together.

Say this verse from memory, and let it shape how you approach God. The holy God has also become your Savior. He sent a seraph with a coal, and, in Christ, he removed your guilt. The one who is holy has made a way for you to stand before him. He calls us to say with the seraphim, and with all creation, "Holy, holy, holy."

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Isaiah and the prophets of the Assyrian crisis. You read about the fast God chooses, the Spirit-anointed one whom Jesus identified as himself, and the great prayer asking God to tear open the heavens. You read God's answer of a new creation, where the wolf and the lamb feed together and sorrow is no more. You then read three short books: Nahum, which announced the fall of the city that once repented; Habakkuk, who argued with God and learned to live by faith, and who rejoiced in the LORD though everything failed; and Zephaniah, who warned of the Day of the LORD and ended with God exulting over his people with loud singing. The week taught that God is holy and just, that faith is the way to live in uncertain times, and that the God who judges is the God who saves.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit covered one of the most important periods in Old Testament history and one of the greatest books of prophecy. King Hezekiah trusted the LORD when Assyria surrounded Jerusalem, spread Sennacherib's letter before him, and saw 185,000 soldiers struck down in a night. Isaiah, who prophesied through the crisis, saw the Lord high and lifted up, heard the cry of "Holy, holy, holy," was cleansed and sent, and announced Immanuel, the child born to us, and the shoot from Jesse's stump. Chapters 40 to 55 gave comfort to exiles and introduced the Servant, who was despised and rejected, pierced for our transgressions, and yet exalted. You paused on the doctrine of the atonement. Chapters 56 to 66 closed with the invitation to everyone who thirsts, the Spirit-anointed herald, and the promise of new heavens and a new earth. Nahum showed that God's patience with Nineveh ended, Habakkuk taught that the righteous shall live by faith, and Zephaniah ended with the God who sings over his people.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does Isaiah's vision of God in chapter 6 teach about worship?

Think about the order of the vision: God's holiness, Isaiah's confession, the cleansing coal, and the call to go. What does each step show about how we come before God, and how does the vision change a person?

Who is the Servant in Isaiah 40-55, and what does he do?

Look at the four Servant Songs (42:1-4, 49:1-6, 50:4-9, 52:13-53:12). Consider his calling, his gentleness, his obedience, and his mission to the nations. How does the New Testament say Jesus fulfills this role (Matthew 12:15-21; Acts 8:32-35)?

How does Isaiah 53 describe substitutionary atonement?

Notice the repeated words “our” and “his.” Write a few sentences about what the Servant bore, why he bore it, and what the result is for those who trust in him. Compare with Romans 3:21-26 and 1 Peter 2:24.

What does “the righteous shall live by his faith” mean in Habakkuk’s context?

Recall the dilemma: injustice in Judah, Babylon coming as a rod, and God’s silence. What does it mean to live by faith when the answer is delayed? Consider Habakkuk 3:17-19 and how Paul uses the verse in Romans 1:17.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the Servant who was pierced for your transgressions.

Thank him for what he has taught you through Isaiah and the prophets.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.